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◉ BJP MANIFESTO

Three free LPG cylinders annually, one lakh government jobs among promises

AGENDA FOR TN. Party launches manifesto, comprising 27 key proposals across 16 sections, on the occasion of Tamil New Year's Day

Our Bureau
Chennai

Ahead of the April 23 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) released its manifesto in Chennai on Tuesday. It has promised a mix of welfare measures and development initiatives, including ₹2,000 monthly assistance for the women heads of households, a one-time ₹10,000 grant for every family and three free LPG cylinders annually during Pongal, Tamil New Year (*puthandu*) and Deepavali.

The manifesto, comprising 27 key promises across 16 sections, was launched on the occasion of Tamil New Year's Day and the birth anniversary of BR Ambedkar by Union Health Minister JP Nadda, in the presence of State BJP chief Nainar Nagenthran, former TN party president K Annamalai, senior leader Tamilisai Soundararajan and Union Minister Piyush Goyal.

Targeting women voters, the party announced a ₹25,000 subsidy for e-scooters and interest-free loans of up to ₹50 lakh for women-led cooperatives, self-help groups and MSMEs, along with a 20 per cent government procurement quota.

TRAINING IN AI

For youth and students, the BJP promised artificial intelligence and robotics training through weekly sessions at Block Resource Centres, ₹10 lakh interest-free loans for first-generation learners, education loan waivers for unemployed graduates and 1 lakh government jobs.

It also pledged free coaching support, district-level training centres with Tamil-medium options and industry-linked skill programmes.

Entrepreneurship and start-ups feature prominently, with interest-free loans of up to ₹15 lakh for 2,000 first-time youth entrepreneurs, along with additional incentives under the PM Surya Ghar scheme.

POLL PROMISES. (left to right) Senior leader Tamilisai Soundararajan, State BJP chief Nainar Nagenthran, Union Health Minister JP Nadda and former BJP Tamil Nadu chief K Annamalai during the launch of the party's manifesto in Chennai on Tuesday BIJOY GHOSH

In agriculture, among other measures, the BJP announced a ₹3,000 State top-up to PM-KISAN, taking annual assistance to ₹9,000, along with a ₹50,000 one-time grant for small and marginal farmers under the Uzhavar Uruthunai scheme.

Interestingly, the party said it would provide one cow breed of geographical importance or two milking goats to small and marginal female farmers, both as a source of income and to safeguard cow breeds that are a cultural insignia of Tamil Nadu.

However, this is not the first time a party has promised to offer cattle. In 2011, then Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa launched the free distribution of milch cows and goats/sheep to beneficiaries, which was well received. In fact, a study on this showed that estimated milk production, which was 54.74 lakh mt in 2005-2006 in Tamil Nadu, increased to 72.44 lakh mt in 2015-2016. Speaking at the launch, BJP leader JP Nadda said, "The cultural capital Tamil Nadu has now been converted into a crime capital. There is full resentment against the DMK, against this dynastic family rule and against crime and corruption. If I talk about drugs, a generation now is being chemically erased. In drug-related offences, the surge is 51 per cent. Now you can imagine what they have done in the past five years."

On law and order, the manifesto promises to crack down on crimes against women through zero-FIR systems, fast-track courts, CCTV coverage in public spaces and improved use of the Nirbhaya Fund.

TACKLING DRUG ABUSE

Addressing drug abuse, the party proposed a dedicated Tamil Nadu Drug Eradication Department, a specialised anti-narcotics task force and stricter enforcement, including capital punishment for repeat offenders under the NDPS Act.

On industrial growth, the party plans to establish 10 plug-and-play industrial parks under the Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana and promote sector-specific corridors.

Infrastructure commitments include expanding rail connectivity through high-speed corridors, such as for Chennai-Bengaluru and Chennai-Hyderabad, and new sleeper Vande Bharat trains linking Chennai with major metros and semi-urban rail networks.

◉ FOCUS ON BENGAL

In his first campaign, Rahul Gandhi slams TMC over corruption

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Launching a blistering attack on West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee for the RG Kar hospital rape-murder case, ponzi schemes and illegal mining in the State, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday said the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) cannot do anything about the mass deletion of voters.

'WILL SET IT RIGHT'

During his first election campaign in the poll-bound State, Gandhi said: "What happened to you in the name of SIR, the deletion of names in the voters list, is an act against the Constitution. Don't be afraid. When the Congress government comes to power, we will make sure that the people, whose name got deleted, become voters again. The Trinamool Congress cannot do anything about this mass deletion of voters. It is only Congress which can fight against the massive voter deletion. The BJP wins elections through this kind of cheating," he said during an election rally at Chanchal in Malda district.

JUDICIAL SCRUTINY

The Muslim-dominated Malda district, which has 12 Assembly constituencies, saw around 2.39 lakh deletions during judicial scrutiny. In the election campaign, Gandhi accused both Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mamata Banerjee of corruption.

He accused Banerjee and TMC of benefiting from ponzi schemes by the Saradha and Rose Valley groups. "Modi is corrupt. Is Mamata *ji* corrupt or not? Saradha chit fund deceived 17 lakh investors, who are yet to receive ₹1,900 crore. Similarly, Rose Valley cheated 31 lakh investors. And these people have not received ₹6,600 crore. Moreover, there is illegal mining and coal scam in Bengal. Everything is being looted here. If anyone is benefiting from all these, they are the Trinamool Congress, its workers and leaders," he said.

On the RG Kar Hospital rape and murder case, he criticised the TMC government, alleging inaction, and questioned its handling of the law and order situation.

EPSTEIN FILES

He also referred to the Epstein files to launch an attack on Modi. "America has control over Narendra Modi. He sold India and West Bengal in the name of the Indo-US deal. He opened our agricultural sector to US farmers, and also compromised India's energy security."

◉ CONSTITUENCY WATCH

One of TN's oldest constituencies, Virudhunagar set for four-way contest

R Balaji
Virudhunagar

A four-way contest is unfolding in Virudhunagar, a trading hub 50 km south of Madurai in south Tamil Nadu. The DMK's ally, the Dravida Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), represented by the 34-year-old Vijaya Prabhakaran V, AIADMK's VG Ganesan, TVK's SP Selvam and Naam Tamizhar Katchi's Lakshmanan are in for a tough battle.

The constituency, among the oldest in Tamil Nadu, is dominated by the Nadar community. It is known for its trading strength, and a significant portion of its vote base has traditionally favoured either the Congress or the DMK.

Also, the Kammavar community has a dominant vote base, along with Nadars and Mukkulathors.

While the DMDK as an ally of the DMK is believed to have an edge, it cannot afford to take for granted the entry of C Joseph Vijay's newly founded Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, which is drawing women voters, first-time voters and the youth.

As an ally of the DMK, Vijaya Prabhakaran has also drawn the ire of party loyalists, who have always considered the DMK as an arch rival.

TOUGH FIGHT. DMDK, represented by the 34-year-old Vijaya Prabhakaran V, campaigns in Virudhunagar R BALAJI

Under the AIADMK alliance in the 2011 Assembly elections, the DMDK emerged as the primary opposition in the Assembly, displacing even the DMK.

DMDK'S CHALLENGE

Talking to *businessline* before starting out on the campaign trail in Virudhunagar, Prabhakaran pointed out that in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, he lost by a mere 4,300 votes to the Indian National Congress' Manickam Tagore, who polled 36.3 per cent votes against his 35.9 per cent.

He believes he can do better this time. He joined the DMDK, now headed by his mother Premallatha V, who is contesting from Vridhachalam, at a time when the party was on the slide following the founder's demise.

On the TVK factor, asked if the party is wooing away youngsters, "it's an issue that affects all parties not just the DMDK," said Prabhakaran. The DMDK, too, had seen such support when it was started two decades back by his father. But Vijayakant loyalists will not shift, he said.

Basic amenities, particularly water supply, remain the major issues in the constituency. Previously, water supply was available only once in two weeks, but now the DMK government had improved the situation to once in four days. The allies are now focusing on ensuring daily supply, he said.

He started his campaign trail accompanied by the incumbent DMK MLA ARR Srinivasan, a three-time MLA from Virudhunagar. At each stop, he highlighted the development measures undertaken by the DMK and promised to continue the good work.

TVK'S TRAIL

At Kammapatti, in Virudhunagar, a group of women and children were seen standing on the roadside waving TVK's yellow and red flag as shrill whistles pierced the air.

Vinitha, a housewife, was there along with her neighbours. Why do they support actor Vijay? The answer is simple. "We like him" is the standard reply. When TVK candidate Selvam entered, the crowds mobbed him.

The group welcomed him ritually with *aarti* while the crowd jostled for selfies. It does not matter if Selvam is not a celebrity — to them he represents Vijay and that is good enough.

A NEW FACE

The AIADMK has fielded a relatively new face — VG Ganesan — an industrialist from neighbouring Sivakasi town, and a member of the Thevar community, which has a strong presence in Sattur and Sivakasi. Whether he can break the DMK's winning streak in this Assembly constituency remains to be seen.

As elections near, Velachery's chronic flooding issue takes centre stage

Rohan Das
Chennai

Velachery, a key constituency in Chennai, will witness an interesting contest, as second-generation politician and incumbent JMH Aassan Maulaana of the Congress is expected to face a tough challenge from AIADMK's ground-level leader MK Ashok. Among Chennai's newly formed constituencies, carved out after a State-wide delimitation in 2008, Velachery evolved from a quiet residential neighbourhood to a bustling hub in south Chennai, linking the city's ever expanding IT corridor with its older central business districts.

Its electorate includes a sizeable population of IT and other white-collar salaried professionals, alongside older residents and some small business owners.

The MLA seat here has been a revolving door, with AIADMK, DMK and Congress having won the constituency after its formation.

In 2021, Maulaana pipped Ashok by a slender margin of 4,352 votes. Ashok himself is no stranger to Velachery, having won the 2011 election from the constituency. The Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) and the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) have also fielded their representatives, though the contest is widely expected to be two-cornered.

Like many other areas in southern Chennai, flooding is a key issue in Velachery. In fact, a recurring sight during monsoon months is the area's massive double-decker bridge lined with parked cars as residents move their vehicles to higher ground.

WOOING VOTERS. AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami (right) campaigning for MK Ashok, who is contesting from the Velachery constituency in Chennai BIJOY GHOSH

"The flooding issue has continued even in years when the rainfall was not that heavy. I think the people here have just accepted it now," a resident told *businessline*. He said that though maintenance work is carried out regularly, it is mostly restricted to main roads, with the streets and smaller roads being ignored.

"The big problem is the roads. When the area is already prone to floods, if the roads are constantly dug open and not properly maintained, obviously it will make things worse," he said.

Another resident pointed to the massive garbage processing station on the Velachery-Tambaram main road, noting that spillovers into nearby localities had caused discomfort.

Meanwhile, infrastructure upgrades in the area over the past few years have received mostly positive feedback, especially the construction of new bridges as well as pedestrian skywalks.

A noteworthy development has been the operationalisation of the elevated rail corridor (Mass Rapid Transit System), which had been delayed for nearly two decades.

Speaking to *businessline*, Maulaana said his government has taken proactive steps to address the flooding issue, including work on the Velachery lake. "We have worked on preparatory measures before rain and have built enough storm drains and sewages to be ready for it," he said. He added that over the next term, he would continue to focus on infrastructure development and complete many of the pending bridge projects in the area.

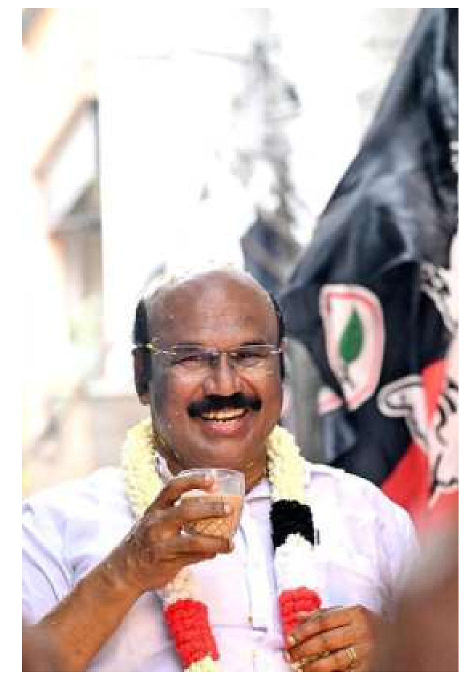
'TAKEN FOR A RIDE'

Meanwhile, addressing the public in one of his campaign events, Ashok alleged that the only achievement of the DMK and Congress legislators after him was successfully cheating the people of Velachery. "The constituency has regressed under their leadership. There has been no development," he said.

Ashok said many residents had not received *patta*, a legal land ownership document, and added that he will expedite the process once elected.

He also promised to replace poorly functioning storm drains in the area and build a flyover in Thiruvanmiyur junction within the constituency.

QUICKLY.



QUICK SIP. D Jayakumar of the AIADMK, who is contesting from the Royapuram constituency in Chennai, takes a tea break during his busy election campaign BIJOY GHOSH

Demand on the rise for campaign holograms

Chennai: The Tamil Nadu Assembly elections are seeing the use of next-gen technologies for campaigning — from banners and videos of yesteryear leaders brought back to life using generative AI to enterprise AI tools deployed to collect and analyse manifesto data. The latest among these innovations is from actor-politician C Joseph Vijay's TVK.

At Kumbakonam in Thanjavur district, a hologram of Vijay (*in picture*) was seen addressing people and campaigning alongside the TVK candidate for the constituency, R Vinoth.

KaaMaa Technologies, a Chennai-based tech company, which developed the portable holographic AI communication system, has seen an increase in demand for the tech post its debut in Kumbakonam. Speaking to *businessline,* Karthick Mari Pitchai, Founder and MD, said that post the deployment by TVK, the company had received multiple inbound requests from other parties to develop similar holograms of its leaders for campaigning. "We have had the teams of many local leaders reach out to us to make similar portable holograms. We are in discussions and should be deploying more of these systems across the State soon. Beyond campaigns, we are also exploring multiple use cases, including public outreach, events and enterprise communication using this technology," he added. ROHAN DAS

'Rahul, Priyanka to start campaigning in TN soon'

Chennai: Tamil Nadu and Puducherry Congress in-charge Girish Chodankar said a decision on the visit of Rahul Gandhi to campaign for the Assembly elections in the State will be announced within the next two to three days. Speaking to reporters ahead of the April 23 Assembly elections, he said Rahul Gandhi, along with Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy and Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, is expected to take part in the election campaign in Tamil Nadu. He added that Priyanka Gandhi will also participate in the campaign. Chodankar said the Congress had appointed in-charges for 28 constituencies, and also for all 234 Assembly constituencies across Tamil Nadu.

He further said Rahul Gandhi and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin are expected to campaign together.

"Rahul Gandhi will come and campaign for Tamil Nadu elections, all our leaders will come... All our leaders will start campaigning when the campaigning becomes very aggressive. We have already appointed party incharges and formed special committees in all 234 Assembly constituencies so that we can help all the allied parties' candidates with whatever forces we have in each Assembly constituency," he added. ANI

2,926 candidates in the fray for Bengal polls

Kolkata: A total of 2,926 candidates are in the fray for the upcoming West Bengal Assembly elections following the completion of the nomination withdrawal process, said the Election Commission on Tuesday.

According to a press note issued by the poll panel, 1,478 candidates will contest in 152 constituencies in the first phase, while 1,448 candidates are in the race for 142 constituencies that will go to the polls in the second phase. The last date for filing nominations for the second phase was April 9, with scrutiny conducted on April 10 and withdrawals permitted till April 13.

A senior Election Commission official said the poll machinery is now fully geared up for the next stage. "With the final list of candidates ready, returning officers will proceed to notify the contesting candidates in the official gazette as per rules," the official told *PTI*.

The commission also reiterated its transparency measures, allowing voters to access details of candidates, including their educational qualifications, criminal antecedents and assets, through the ECINet mobile application. PTI

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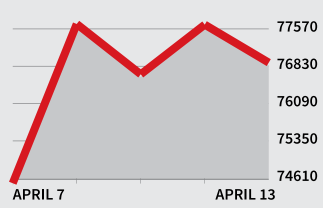

IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23842.65	+874.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.12	+0.75
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.38	+0.32
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149410.00	+1107
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	236981.00	+2938

REGAINING GLITTER. **Investments in gold ETFs** turned positive in the past fortnight, per data from the World Gold Council **p8**

TRUCE TALKS. **Teams from US and Iran** may return to Islamabad this week to resume talks to end the war **p3**

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QUICKLY.

SIAM DATA

Auto sales hit record high of 2.83 crore units in FY26

New Delhi: India's automobile wholesales grew by double digits in all four major segments — passenger vehicles, two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial vehicles — with total sales of 2,82,65,519 units in FY26. As per the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), the grand total grew 10.4 per cent against 2,56,09,399 units in FY25. The industry body said the last time when all the segments posted record sales was in FY19. **p2**

India may go slow on trade deal till US mid-term polls

ON HOLD. Any change in the composition of Congress could restrain the President on tariffs

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India is likely to play for time in its trade talks with the US when negotiators meet in Washington soon, as it looks to the upcoming US mid-term elections to provide clarity on the American legislative landscape, sources have said.

Following the US Supreme Court invalidating reciprocal taxes on February 20, the current 10 per cent global tariff imposed by the Trump administration for a 90-day period has become a temporary floor that India does not want to negotiate until the "end game" numbers are settled.

KEY MID-TERMS

"India would want to continue to talk, but obviously it needs to know where the US stands before it gives anything. We will not know that before the mid-term elections in November as the fate of tariffs is tied to how the Trump regime fares," a source explained.

EYES ON POLL OUTCOME. All 435 seats in the US House of Representatives and about a third of the 100 seats in the US Senate will come up for vote on November 3 BLOOMBERG

The mid-term elections, held at the midpoint of a President's term, are crucial as they could lead to a significant shift in the composition of Congress. Currently, all 435 seats in the US House of Representatives and about a third of the 100 seats in the US Senate are up for vote on November 3.

If Democrats take the House, the President's ability to pass major legislation, including sweeping tax and tariff reforms, would largely come to a halt.

The US, however, wants India back at the negotiating table. US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor recently underlined in a social media post that a trade deal between the two had been previously agreed to, noting that an Indian delegation is expected in Washington later this month.

Gor was referring to the preliminary India-US interim bilateral trade deal framework announced on February 2, 2026. Under the framework, India agreed to eliminate or lower tariffs on most industrial goods and agricultural products, while the US agreed to lower reciprocal tariffs to 18 per cent from 25 per cent.

However, India can no longer settle on those specific terms as the landscape shifted dramatically following the Supreme Court's ruling, which struck down the legal foundation for the broad reciprocal tariffs.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal recently emphasised that India must secure preferential access over its competitors, as was agreed to in the initial framework.

Since India only signed a framework and not a final legal treaty, it has no obligation to proceed under the old terms. "If the Trump administration loses ground in the mid-terms, its negotiating position may weaken, allowing New Delhi to push for greater concessions," the source said.

PLAN B

As a 'Plan B,' the Trump regime has initiated Section 301 investigations against several countries, including India. While this allows the executive to impose penalties without Congressional approval, it requires the US Trade Representative to prove a foreign government is engaging in unfair acts, which is difficult to carry out for each country.

Uttar Pradesh hikes minimum pay by up to 21% after workers' protests

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

KEEPING VIGIL. Security personnel conducting a march in Sector 80 amid workers' protests in Noida on Tuesday PTI

The Uttar Pradesh government has announced an interim increase in minimum wages for workers, effective April 1, on the recommendation of a high-level committee constituted following violent protests in Noida demanding better remuneration and working conditions.

The revised minimum wage rates, which have gone up from a minimum of 9.21 per cent to a maximum of about 21 per cent, will be implemented across three different categories — Gautam Buddh Nagar or Noida-Ghaziabad, for districts with municipal corporations, and the remaining districts of Uttar Pradesh.

WAGE HIKES

For Gautam Buddh Nagar or Noida-Ghaziabad districts, which lead the regions with maximum raise, unskilled workers' wages have been increased to ₹13,690 from ₹11,313 (up 14.97 per cent). Semi-skilled workers' wages in these two districts will be hiked to ₹15,059 from ₹12,445 (up 14.95 per cent) and for skilled workers to ₹16,025 from ₹13,940 (14.96 per cent), per a government statement. In other districts, the interim hike is the least at about 9.21 per cent.

Now, unskilled workers will be paid ₹12,356 in place of ₹11,313, semi-skilled ₹13,591 (₹12,445), and skilled ₹15,224 (₹13,940).

WELFARE MEASURES

Announcing a series of worker welfare measures to quell the unrest ahead of the Uttar Pradesh elections that are due in 2027, District Magistrate of Gautam Buddha Nagar Medha Roopam urged labourers to maintain peace as "violence is not the answer."

"I thank the Chief Minister and the high-powered committee for accepting the workers' primary demand of wage increase. Furthermore, other directives have been issued, including ensuring that workers' wages are credited to their accounts before the 10th of every month," she said.

WORKERS' RIGHTS

The welfare package also includes additional benefits to safeguard workers' rights.

"Bonuses will also be paid before November of each year. Double pay will be paid for overtime work. Double pay will also be paid for working on weekly holidays. Sexual harassment committees will be formed everywhere. Women will chair these committees. Complaint boxes will also be available," Roopam said.

Infrastructure and Industrial Development Commissioner Deepak Kumar had earlier stated that workers were demanding wage hikes due to inflation and alleged that the violence was carried out by "outsiders."

FIR filed in Pune against Anand Rathi Wealth senior executives on sexual harassment charges

Our Bureaus
Pune/Mumbai

A 33-year-old woman employee of Anand Rathi Wealth has alleged sexual harassment and intimidation by five senior officials, even as the firm dismissed the complaint as "frivolous".

The FIR, registered by the complainant at the Shivajinagar police station on April 10, names Swapan Chakraborty (Executive Director), Rakesh Rawal (Chief Executive Officer), Feroze Azeez (Joint Chief Executive Officer), Tejal Shah (Head–Human Resources), and Sonali Rawal (Executive Director).

ALLEGED OFFENCES

According to the FIR filed in Pune, the alleged offences occurred between May 2024 and April 8, 2026.

The complainant has alleged that Chakraborty attempted to make physical advances towards her and, on multiple occasions, used force amounting to outraging her modesty.

She further alleged that he persistently followed her and issued threats that her career would be jeopardised if she pursued a complaint against him.

"This is a frivolous matter against the senior executives (CEO, Joint CEO and the other two women employees mentioned in the FIR) of the company and all necessary legal steps are being taken," the company reiterated in a statement made earlier.

The company declined to make any further comment on the matter as it is *sub-judice*, but said that it was co-operating with the authorities and submitting the required documents.

The FIR states that despite lodging an internal complaint regarding sexual harassment, no action was taken by the organisation.

Instead, the complainant alleged that Chakraborty was supported, while she faced hostility at the workplace and was subsequently transferred to Dubai in a purported act of victimisation.

UNDER THE LENS

The case is currently under investigation by sub-inspector Jadhav of the Shivajinagar police station.

Company insiders said that initially the complainant had approached the NM Joshi Marg police station in Mumbai last year to file a complaint but then did not appear when she was called to record her statement, following which the case was closed.

The company's stand is that while the complainant was repeatedly called to the police station for inquiry and register a formal case, she avoided registering the offence.

AUSPICIOUS START

SOLAR NEW YEAR. People throng the banks of the Ganga at Har Ki Pauri in Haridwar, Uttarakhand, on the occasion of the 'Mesha Sankranti' festival on Tuesday. 'Mesha Sankranti' is considered an auspicious day as it marks the beginning of a new year, according to the solar calendar PTI

When your CCTV turns its eye on you

Hackers are breaching networks with default passwords such as '123456', 'welcome'

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

CCTVs, or closed-circuit televisions, are meant to be the eyes on our properties. But they turn out to be doing exactly the opposite — giving out our information to the enemy. The hacker is watching the same footage that you have been watching.

Most hackers don't need to sweat it out to breach CCTV networks. They simply use factory-set default passwords such as 'welcome', 'admin123' or '123456' as most companies and residential complexes want to keep it 'simple'.

MAJOR VULNERABILITY

The recent revelation that Pakistan could sneak into our CCTV networks at strategic locations via Chinese products sent shockwaves across the country. But this is not confined to India alone.

Cybersecurity firm Check Point's research found that IP cameras (those connected to the internet) were targeted across Israel, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, the UAE, Cyprus and Lebanon.

Hackers breaking into CCTV networks has become a major cybersecurity vulnerability. Here are some chilling facts — in November 2025, authorities dismantled a massive cybercrime ring that compromised 80 CCTV dashboards across 20 States. Over nine months, hackers stole at least 50,000 video clips from hospitals, schools, offices and homes in Pune, Mumbai, Surat and Delhi. They sold the footage online for ₹700 to ₹4,000 per clip, feeding an international voyeuristic network.

"For thousands of Indian families and businesses, this nightmare became real. And, now, a far more chilling reality has emerged: A foreign intelligence agency may have been watching us," Kiran Vangaveti, Founder and Chief Executive Officer of cybersecurity company BluSapphire, told *businessline*.

'A WAKE-UP CALL'

He felt that this episode was a rude wake-up call. "It forced the government to act swiftly. From April 1, any internet-connected CCTV device sold in India must pass stringent security certification standards. Major foreign manufacturers have been effectively barred unless they meet these requirements. Indian brands like CP Plus, Qubo and Matrix now control over 80 per cent of the market," he said.

Check Point Research said in a blog that the attacks on CCTVs surged during the peak of the ongoing war in West Asia.

In a blog post on CCTV espionage, it asked organisations to remove direct WAN (wide area network) access to cameras and place them behind a VPN or a zero-trust access (no one except the designated person) gateway. It wanted them to change default passwords and enforce unique credentials.

Vangaveti asked users to install software updates from manufacturers and retire end-of-life devices that no longer receive security fixes.

Experts have also flagged the dangers involved in cloud-based video feeds.

Lok Sabha expansion to 850 seats: New Bill seeks to replace 'Census-first' with 'delimitation-first' model

Poornima Joshi
Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi/Chennai

The proposed Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-first Amendment) Bill, 2026, which seeks to expand the strength of the Lok Sabha from 543 to a maximum of 850 seats, marks a fundamental shift in India's electoral framework by decoupling seat expansion and women's reservation from the rigid requirement of waiting for a fresh decennial Census.

The move effectively replaces a "Census-first" model, where seat redistribution automatically followed a new population count, with a "delimitation-first" approach, under which a Delimitation Commission will redraw constituencies using the most recent Census figures that Parliament chooses to notify. In practical terms, this means that seat redistribution may proceed without waiting for the next full Census cycle.

NEW FRAMEWORK. The Bill aims at redrawing constituencies using existing Census data, paving the way for women's reservation

POLITICAL REACTIONS

The timing of Parliament's special session, convened amid crucial Assembly elections in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, has drawn sharp reactions. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin issued a strong warning on Tuesday against any delimitation exercise that could dilute the representation of the southern States. "If anything is done that harms Tamil Nadu or that disproportionately enhances the political power of northern States, we in Tamil Nadu will not remain silent," he said.

At the heart of the Bill are amendments to Articles 82 and 170, which remove the earlier clause mandating that readjustment of seats take place only "upon the completion of the first Census taken after 2026".

Instead, the amendments empower a Delimitation Commission to redraw constituencies based on the most recent published Census figures that Parliament considers appropriate, effectively clearing the legal path to rely on 2011 Census data. This shift to a delimitation-driven framework is also the mechanism through which the Bill proposes a substantial expansion of Parliament. By amending Article 81, the legislation raises the maximum strength of the Lok Sabha to 850 members, up to 815 from the States and 35 from the Union Territories, representing roughly a 50 per cent increase in seats.

The expansion is intended to accommodate demographic changes and ensure that the implementation of the 33 per cent reservation for women does not reduce the number of seats currently available to general candidates.

POPULATION CRITERIA

For purposes of representation, the Bill also redefines "population" across multiple constitutional provisions, including Articles 55 and 170, to mean figures from a Census determined by Parliament. This provision allows the government to bypass delays caused by the postponed 2021 Census and proceed with the redrawing of electoral boundaries.

Also read p9

QUICKLY.

BP to reorganise into upstream, downstream

London: BP will reorganise into two main business units — one for upstream and one for downstream under new CEO Meg O'Neill, a spokesperson said on Tuesday. "In service of becoming a simpler, stronger, more valuable BP, we intend to build an organisation with a clear upstream and downstream," the spokesperson said, confirming an earlier *Financial Times* report about the change. REUTERS

New Renault Duster deliveries begin

Chennai: Renault India, a wholly owned subsidiary of the French carmaker Renault Group, on Tuesday commenced nationwide customer deliveries of the new Renault Duster across India. The first delivery also coincides with the brand's inauguration of its new store on Mount Road in Chennai. OUR BUREAU

Auto wholesales clock record 2.82 crore units in FY26: SIAM

WHAT'S WORRYING. Iran conflict, crude price, commodities and higher exchange rates

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Automobile wholesales (despatches to dealers) grew by double digits in all four major segments — passenger vehicles (PVs), two-wheelers (2Ws), three-wheelers (3Ws) and commercial vehicles (CVs) — with total sales of 2,82,65,519 units in FY26. The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) said the grand total rose 10.4 per cent as compared with 2,56,09,399 units in FY25. The last time when all the segments posted highest-ever sales was in FY19.

SIAM noted that although the outlook for the ongoing fiscal is positive considering the strong fundamentals of the economy, if the West Asia war prolongs, it could impact demand, supply chain and vehicle production. "The West Asia conflict, prices of crude oil and commodities, higher exchange rates and disruptions in shipping routes remain a concern. A stable geopolitical environment will help build confidence, which can in turn drive further growth in 2026-27," Shailesh Chandra, President, SIAM, said. He added that positive sentiment created through GST 2.0 and repo rate cut remain.

Domestic automobile sales in FY26

Category	April-March 2024-25	April-March 2025-26	% change
Passenger vehicles	43,01,848	46,43,439	7.9
Two-wheelers	1,96,07,332	2,17,05,974	10.7
Three-wheelers	7,41,420	8,36,231	12.8
Commercial vehicles	9,58,679	10,79,871	12.6
Grand total *(including others)*	**2,56,09,399**	**2,82,65,519**	**10.4**

Source: SIAM   in units

A HIGH NOTE

Chandra said though FY26 started modestly, the industry closed the year on a high note with every vehicle category posting highest-ever sales in a financial year, after seven years. "In FY26, passenger vehicles posted sales of 46.43 lakh units with a growth of 7.9 per cent, commercial vehicles posted sales of 10.80 lakh units with a growth of 12.6 per cent, three-wheelers posted sales of 8.36 lakh units with a growth of 12.8 per cent, and two-wheelers posted sales of 2.17 crore units, with a growth of 10.7 per cent, over FY25," Chandra added.

Both PVs and 2Ws posted highest-ever exports in FY26. PV exports grew by 17.5 per cent at more than 9.05 lakh units in FY26 as compared with around 7.70 lakh in FY25. The demand has been steady across most markets. Two-wheeler exports reached more than 51.8 lakh units in FY26 with a growth of 23.4 per cent against more than 41.98 lakh units in FY25.

VISUALLY.

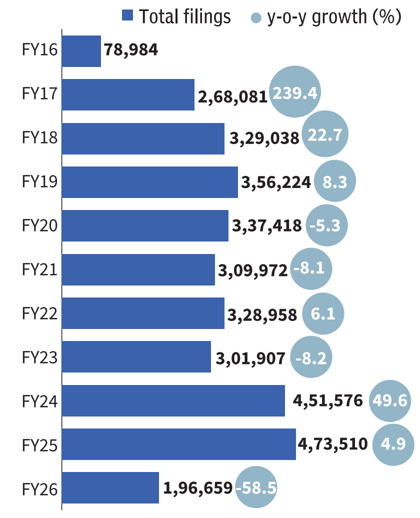
Compiled by **Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

IP registrations see sharp swings

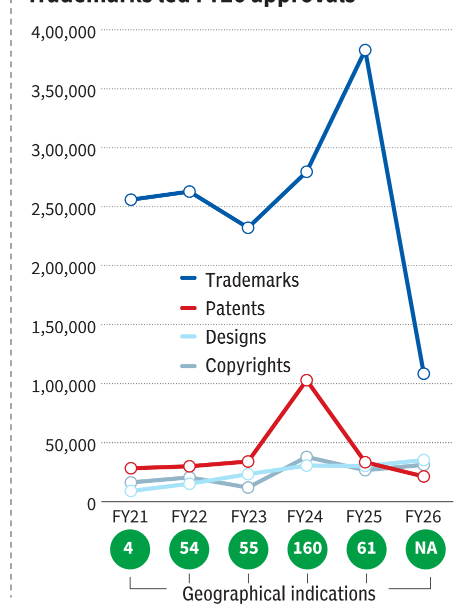
After reaching record highs in FY24 and FY25, India's total IP grants and registrations by the Office of the Controller General of Patents, Designs & Trade Marks (CGPDTM) fell 58.5% in FY26. While trademarks continued to dominate approvals and disposals, registrations remained concentrated in a few major States, and patent grants were largely driven by technology-led sectors

Total IP registrations plunge 58.5% in FY26 after peaking at 4.73 lakh in FY25

Year-wise IP applications granted/registered

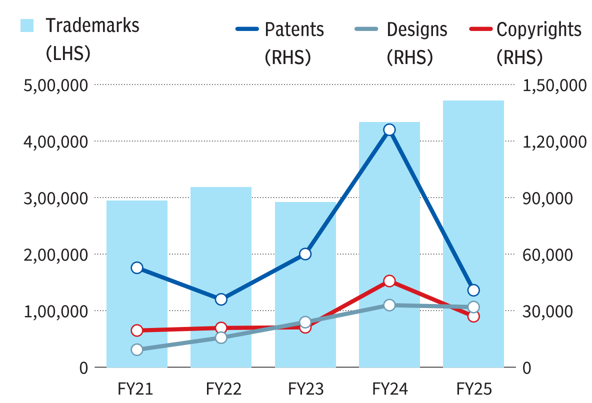


Trademarks led FY26 approvals



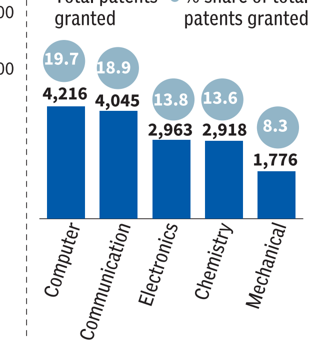
Rejections highest in trademark applications

Disposal of applications include IPs granted or refused by the patent office, as well as applications abandoned or withdrawn by applicants



Nearly three-fourths of all patents granted in technology fields

Patents granted by field on invention (FY26)



State-wise concentration of IP granted/registered (FY26)

Patents granted	Designs	Trademarks	Copyrights
Maharashtra **(1,876)**	Maharashtra **(7,039)**	Maharashtra **(19,480)**	Maharashtra **(10,618)**
Tamil Nadu **(1,152)**	Tamil Nadu **(3,385)**	Delhi **(14,286)**	Delhi **(2,782)**
Karnataka **(1,022)**	Delhi **(2,847)**	Gujarat **(11,003)**	Tamil Nadu **(2,354)**
Delhi **(726)**	Gujarat **(2,578)**	Uttar Pradesh **(8,335)**	Uttar Pradesh **(1,986)**
Gujarat **(721)**	Uttar Pradesh **(2,440)**	Haryana **(6,312)**	Karnataka **(1,831)**

Source: IP dashboard, Intellectual Property India Annual Report, WIPO

Delhi EV policy draft draws mixed reactions

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The draft Delhi Electric Vehicle (EV) policy should extend across the National Capital Region (NCR) as limiting benefits to Delhi alone will create distortions, because vehicles are purchased and operated across Gurugram, Faridabad and the broader NCR, said Anjali Rattan, Chairperson, RattanIndia Enterprises.

The maker of Revolt electric motorcycles said EV sector requires significant long-term investments to scale, and therefore, a clear, stable, and forward-looking policy roadmap is essential to build investor confidence and drive sustained growth.

"If Delhi wants meaningful EV scale, motorcycles are the real lever. Electrifying this segment will deliver the biggest impact on emissions, fuel savings, and overall adoption," Rattan told *businessline*.

Leading two-wheeler companies such as Hero MotoCorp said they were still reviewing the draft policy. Queries sent to Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India, TVS Motor Company and Bajaj Auto remained unanswered.

Meanwhile, the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) said the policy should be enabling rather than putting in place a lot of mandates.

"Our position from SIAM has been that enablers are the best way to promote EVs, and not mandate. The government has definitely taken the route of the enabler. We also have to see that the draft policy ensures that it does not move towards too many mandates. But, definitely these policies have the full intention of driving the adoption of EVs," Shailesh Chandra, President, SIAM, told reporters.

According to the draft EV policy, from January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers would be be permitted for new registration in the NCT of Delhi, and from April 1, 2028, only electric two-wheelers will be allowed for fresh registration.

GREAT OPPORTUNITY

Analysts said while this transition presents a strong opportunity for EV makers, traditional players will need to strategically realign, recalibrate, and re-plan operations to stay competitive.

"Most legacy OEMs (Bajaj, Hero, Honda and TVS) already have EV portfolios; however, the focus must now shift towards scaling up for mass production. This transition is challenging particularly given the industry's significant dependence on China-centric supply chains," Puneet Gupta, Director, Sales and Powertrain Forecast, India & ASEAN, S&P, said. Gupta said charging infrastructure could be a bottleneck, but not a blocker EV growth. "Some challenges will be there, but, the government is not banning the entire fleet. It's limited to new vehicles only."

"Even when CNG was implemented there was nothing, but gradually we saw growth in the number of pumps. I think the key driver is making people breathe healthy," Gupta added.

Rattan said while two-wheelers are relatively easier to manage, with options such as portable batteries and simple three-pin charging, charging infrastructure is a much bigger challenge for three-wheelers and four-wheelers compared to two-wheelers.

'SEIL Energy India will not diversify for optics'

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

SEIL Energy India Ltd, wholly-owned by Tanweer Infrastructure SAOC, is open to evaluating well-performing assets going through IBC resolutions.

Janmejaya Mahapatra, Whole-time Director & CEO, SEIL Energy, explaining the company's future plans, told *businessline*, "We do not mind evaluating well-performing assets going through IBC resolutions, that offer clear operational synergies and has potential to strengthen returns without diluting our focus."

"SEIL will not diversify for optics. For now, SEIL is focused on maintaining financial stability and operational excellence, our priority is to keep this 2,640 MW plant in excellent condition, so that it runs at its peak not only for the 25 years of useful life, but for 40 years and up to 2056," he said.

> For now, SEIL is focused on maintaining financial stability and operational excellence
>
> **JANMEJAYA MAHAPATRA**
> Whole-time Director & CEO, SEIL Energy

SEIL's journey began in 2008 on the eastern coast of India, near Krishnapatnam Port in Nellore, Andhra Pradesh. Today, with about 95 per cent of its 2,640 MW supercritical capacity contracted, SEIL Energy supplies power to Andhra Pradesh (1,484 MW), Telangana (270 MW), Haryana (127 MW), Tamil Nadu (100 MW), and Bangladesh (450 MW).

Asked whether the challenges once faced with Bangladesh exports have been sorted, he said: "The company is successfully exporting 450 MW of power to Bangladesh."

DOMESTIC FRONT

On the domestic front issues faced with the Power Purchase Agreements, he said, "Stable PPAs are crucial for investor confidence. Long-term or medium-term PPAs give comfort to the investors, especially in infrastructure projects like power plants, which are highly capital intensive."

"Regulatory hassles or delayed payments can make investors wary, making them shy away from further investments. Implementation of late payment surcharge (LPS) rules and CERC taking a stable role of guiding the State regulatory commissions in creating a very uniform jurisprudence have given a fillip to this sector," he pointed out.

EVOLVING ROLE

On coal's evolving role in India's energy mix, he said: "The thermal power sector has moved from maintaining a constant base load to a flexible operation model that integrates renewable energy sources. This flexibility is crucial for adapting to the intermittency of renewables."

"Its role has matured beyond base load supply to active ramping, flexibilisation, and integration of intermittent renewables. Particularly, supercritical plants have a promising future, with stability for the next two decades, providing stability through at least 2047," he added.

Mindspace REIT acquires 51% in Chennai IT park for ₹3,000 crore

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Mindspace Business Parks REIT acquired a 51 per cent stake in the 2.6 million sq ft International Tech Park Chennai (ITPC) on Radial Road for about ₹3,000 crore, marking one of the largest office transactions in India in recent years.

The seller is AIGP2 Chennai 1 Pte Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of CapitaLand India Growth Fund 2, while 360 ONE Asset will hold the remaining 49 per cent stake through its real assets funds.

The acquisition will be executed via Radial IT Park Private Ltd, the holding entity of the asset.

Located on the Pallavaram–Thoraipakkam Road corridor, the campus comprises two towers of around 1.3 million sq ft each.

HCG to add 1,000 beds over five years as cancer care demand rises

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based cancer care chain HealthCare Global Enterprises (HCG) is stepping up its expansion plans, targeting a significant capacity increase over the next five years, even as competition and capital flows intensify in the healthcare space.

The company plans to add at least 1,000 beds over the next five years, taking its total capacity beyond the current 2,500 beds, Dr Manish Mattoo, CEO and Executive Director, HCG, told *businessline*.

The expansion will be driven through a mix of greenfield projects and brownfield additions. Around 400 beds are expected at new facilities, while the remaining 500–600 beds will be added by expanding existing hospitals. HCG,

Dr Manish Mattoo, CEO and Executive Director, HCG

which operates 25 hospitals across 19 cities, including an international centre in Kenya, has historically focused on expanding oncology access beyond metros, entering tier-2 markets such as Vijayawada, Visakhapatnam and Bhavnagar.

POTENTIAL CITIES

This strategy is expected to continue, with the company identifying 12–13 potential cities, including Pune, Surat, Kolkata, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Chennai and Coimbatore, for future growth.

Alongside organic expansion, the company is keeping the inorganic route open. "We're not ruling out mergers and acquisitions. Opportunities for standalone cancer centres or chains do come up, and we will actively evaluate them," Mattoo said, pointing to private equity backing from KKR as an enabler for scale and consolidation.

EXPANSION PUSH

The expansion push comes amid a broader surge in investments and capacity creation across India's healthcare sector, particularly in high-complexity areas such as oncology.

However, Mattoo emphasised that scale alone will not be the differentiator.

Zappfresh's parent 'scouting for more acquisitions'

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

DSM Fresh Foods Ltd, the parent company of fresh meat food brand Zappfresh, is continuing to scout for strategic acquisition opportunities, as it aims to diversify its food play.

The company recently forayed into the frozen vegetarian snack category with the launch of its brand, Meevaa Foods, with a focus on domestic and international

Deepanshu Manchanda, MD, DSM Fresh Foods

markets. In January, it had announced that it is acquiring Ambrosia Frozen Food's food processing business through Avyom Foodtech.

Deepanshu Manchanda, MD, DSM Fresh Foods, told *businessline*, "Our vision is to offer a basket of products in the fresh meat, frozen, ready-to-cook and eat segments. We want to diversify into value-added, adjacent categories that have high margins . Hence, we are planning to continue to look at more acquisitions that are value-accretive and compliment our existing portfolio."

> **DSM Fresh recently forayed into the frozen vegetarian snack category** with the launch of its brand Meevaa Foods

The company is looking at inorganic growth opportunities in categories such as frozen food products, ready-to-cook and eat as well as spices among others.

With the launch of Meevaa Foods, the company is strengthening its play in ready-to-cook and eat products.

"Our recent acquisition in the frozen and processed foods segment enabled us to fast-track our diversification vision, allowing us to bring our frozen food range to market within few weeks. With Meevaa Foods, we want to cater to a wider base of consumer beyond non-vegetarian food space and diversify our presence into international markets. While we will deepen the brand's India distribution, we are also tapping into markets such as the US, UK and Europe," he added.

NEW PRODUCTS

Manchanda said the company will keep rolling out new products to rapidly grow Meevaa Foods. "In this fiscal year, we are targeting revenues of ₹70 crore from the frozen category in the new subsidiary," he added.

In terms of overall distribution expansion, the company is looking at deepening its presence in the southern and western regions.

Infra buildout 'driving digital twins demand'

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

As India accelerates large-scale infrastructure buildout, infrastructure engineering software player Bentley Systems is seeing rising demand for digital twin technology, as per company executives. Governments are increasingly adopting real-time digital replicas of physical assets to improve coordination, cut risks, and enable predictive maintenance.

"A big part of what we're doing with India is positioning digital twins as essential national infrastructure enablers. We're seeing strong demand from Indian government agencies seeking technology to deliver projects faster with greater coordination. We position digital twins as not add-ons, but foundational infrastructure capabilities that support integrated planning and coordination. We're looking to support and build a long-term ecosystem in India," said Dave Philp, Chief Value Officer at Bentley Systems.

DIGITAL TWIN

A digital twin, he explained, is a real-time representation of infrastructure that stays connected to the physical asset across its entire lifecycle — from planning and design to construction, and operation and maintenance. It brings together engineering models, geospatial contexts, construction data, and live operational inputs into a single environment. The twin then evolves as the asset changes.

This allows stakeholders to simulate scenarios, test designs before committing capital, and understand how systems interact at a network or city level.

With real-time monitoring, digital twins enable predictive maintenance, helping detect issues before failures occur, and shift infrastructure management from reactive to proactive.

Rehearsing different conditions in a virtual environment reduces design errors, shortens project timelines, and lowers construction risk.

This technology is being applied to solve challenges in India's projects, like the Pinnapuram Integrated Renewable Energy Project in Andhra Pradesh.

As a large integrated solar, wind, and pumped-storage hydro project, it faced geotechnical challenges.

DIGITAL-FIRST

The engineering consultancy AFRY turned to GeoStudio software from Seequent, a Bentley company, to digitally model and analyse everything from slope stability to the integrity of the 40-metre-high rockfill dams, ensuring the project's viability before breaking ground.

Philip observed that governments, especially in India, are taking a digital-first approach to infrastructure development.

Kamalakannan Thiruvadi, Regional Executive for South Asia at Bentley Systems, said India represents a significant infrastructure market, with a focus on sectors such as transportation.

QUICKLY.

Modi, Trump discuss Strait of Hormuz security

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi held a telephonic discussion with US President Donald Trump on the situation in West Asia, underlining the need to keep the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) open and secure. "Received a call from my friend President Donald Trump. We reviewed the substantial progress achieved in our bilateral cooperation in various sectors. We are committed to further strengthening our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership in all areas. We also discussed the situation in West Asia and stressed the importance of keeping the Strait of Hormuz open and secure," Modi posted on social media platform X on Tuesday. US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor described the call as "very positive and productive" in a post highlighting Modi's update on the interaction. The SoH is a crucial waterway for India, as it acts as the gateway for nearly half of its crude oil and 85 per cent of its liquefied petroleum gas imports. Disruptions in the strait also affect India's exports to the Gulf countries and to major markets such as the US and the EU, due to forced rerouting. OUR BUREAU

US, Iran may resume war talks this week despite port blockade

RAY OF HOPE. Positive sign helps push benchmark prices below $100 on Tuesday

Reuters/Press Trust of India
Islamabad/Washington/Dubai/Beirut

IRAN'S WARNING. Tehran has threatened to hit naval ships going through the Strait and to retaliate against its Gulf neighbours' ports REUTERS

Negotiating teams from the US and Iran could return to Islamabad this week to resume talks to end the war, sources told *Reuters* on Tuesday, after the collapse of weekend negotiations prompted Washington to impose a blockade on Iranian ports.

While the US blockade drew angry rhetoric from Tehran, signs that diplomatic engagement might continue helped calm oil markets, pushing benchmark prices below $100 on Tuesday.

The highest-level talks between the two adversaries since the 1979 Islamic Revolution ended in Islamabad without a breakthrough. But a source involved in the talks said on Tuesday both countries could return as early as the end of this week, and that a proposal had been shared with Washington and Tehran to resend their delegations.

"No firm date has been set, with the delegations keeping Friday through Sunday open," a senior Iranian source said.

US President Donald Trump said Iran had been in touch on Monday and wanted to make a deal, adding that he would not sanction any agreement that allowed Tehran to possess a nuclear weapon.

Since the US and Israel began the war on February 28, Iran effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz to all vessels except its own. The fallout has been widespread, as nearly a fifth of the world's oil and gas previously flowed through the narrow waterway. In a counter measure, the US military began blocking shipping traffic in and out of Iran's ports on Monday. Tehran has threatened to hit naval ships going through the strait and to retaliate against its Gulf neighbours' ports.

The US blockade has further clouded the outlook for global energy security and the supply of a vast array of goods that rely on petroleum. Its NATO allies, including Britain and France, said they would not be drawn into the conflict by taking part in the blockade, stressing instead the need to reopen the waterway.

'MADE PROGRESS'

US Vice-President JD Vance, who led Washington's delegation opposite Iran's Speaker of Parliament Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, told Fox News on Monday that the US had "made a lot of progress" by communicating to Tehran where Washington "could make some accommodation" and where it would remain inflexible.

An Iranian military spokesperson called any US restrictions on international shipping "piracy," warning that if Iranian ports were threatened, no port in the Gulf or Gulf of Oman would be secure. Any military vessels approaching the strait would violate the ceasefire, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said.

The US military's Central Command said the blockade would be enforced against vessels entering or leaving Iranian ports in the Gulf and Gulf of Oman.

Three Iran-linked tankers were seen transiting the Strait of Hormuz on the first full day of the US blockade on Tuesday, shipping data showed. As the vessels were not heading to or from Iranian ports, they were not covered by the blockade.

ISRAEL-LEBANON TALKS

Meanwhile, Lebanon and Israel are set to hold the first direct diplomatic talks in decades on Tuesday in Washington following more than a month of war between Israel and the Hezbollah militant group.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will take part in the talks in Washington with Israeli Ambassador to the US Yechiel Leiter and Lebanese Ambassador to the US Nada Hamadeh Moawad.

Hezbollah opposes the direct talks and will not be represented. Wafiq Safa, a high-ranking member of the militant group's political council, told the *Associated Press* that it will not abide by any agreements made in the talks.

Oil prices hit new high in March as refiners try to replace West Asian grades: IEA

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The International Energy Agency (IEA) said that crude oil prices recorded their highest monthly gain in March 2026, with North Sea Dated trading at $130 per barrel, as refiners scrambled to replace West Asian grades.

Refiners in India are also impacted in terms of crude oil supplies considering the world's third-largest exporter sourced more than 50 per cent of its imports from the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region before the latest escalation in hostilities between Iran and the US (February 28).

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) has exacerbated India's crude oil shipments from Iraq, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. However, Indian refiners have diversified supplies reducing their dependence on West Asia and the SoH to 30 per cent currently, which helps it get assured cargoes, albeit at record-high prices. High prices coupled with a weak rupee is adversely impacting India's current account deficit.

In its oil market report for April 2026, the IEA pointed out that global oil supply plummeted by 10.1 million barrels per day (mb/d) to 97 mb/d in March, with continued attacks on energy infrastructure in West Asia and ongoing restrictions to tanker movements through the SoH leading to the largest disruption in history.

"Oil prices posted their largest-ever monthly gain in March in the wake of the most-severe oil supply shock in history. Spot crude benchmarks and differentials soared, outpacing futures markets, as refiners anxiously scrambled to replace locked in West Asian cargoes," it added.

CEASEFIRE RELIEF

At the time of writing, North Sea Dated crude was trading $60 above pre-conflict levels. The IEA noted that last week's announcement of a two-week ceasefire provided some welcome respite to global oil markets just as the impact of disruptions to supply and trade were spreading globally.

However, it remains unclear whether the ceasefire will turn into a lasting peace and a return to regular shipping flows through the SoH.

With oil-importing nations scrambling to source replacement barrels from an increasingly shrinking pool of supply, physical crude oil prices surged to record levels near $150 per barrel, far above the prices in futures markets, with the physical-futures disconnect becoming increasingly acute. Even steeper gains have been seen for refined products, with middle distillate prices in Singapore reaching all-time highs above $290 per barrel.

S&P Global Energy pointed out that a fragile US-Iran ceasefire with no major missile attacks, despite the US blockade of Iranian ports going into effect, and reports of a second round of talks being considered are 'neutral' for global gas and LNG prices.

Ships going to and from Iranian ports have not openly challenged the US blockade yet, but the risk of miscalculation and retaliation remains high. Iran has said it would target Gulf port infrastructure if its vessels are threatened, said Eric Yep, Senior principal analyst for First Take Gas at S&P Global Energy CERA.

"The likelihood of stranded ships, including laden LNG carriers, evacuating quickly from the SoH during the ceasefire has now decreased significantly. The risks are emanating from a lack of clarity on what the US blockade means and how Iran will respond. A full naval blockade would stop everything from Iranian oil exports to imports of essential and non-essential goods and materials, including food supplies," he added.

If the blockade cripples the Iranian economy, it risks triggering an escalatory response. The control of SoH will remain a key concern for markets in the coming weeks, Yep emphasised.

IMF ups India's growth forecast to 6.5% for FY27

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) on Tuesday upped India's growth forecast by 30 basis points to 6.5 per cent for fiscal year 2026-27 (FY27). However, the global forecast has been revised downward by 20 bps to 3.1 per cent for 2026.

"For 2026 (FY2026-27), growth is revised upward moderately by 0.3 percentage point (0.1 percentage point relative to January) to 6.5 per cent, led by positive contributions from the carryover of the strong 2025 out-turn and the decline in additional US tariffs on Indian goods from 50 per cent to 10 per cent, which outweigh the adverse impact of the West Asia conflict," IMF said in its latest edition of World Economic Outlook. This is second upward revision for Indian economy after World Bank increased the estimates by 30 basis points to 6.6 per cent.

Further, IMF said that growth for 2025 (FY2025-26) is revised upward by 1 percentage point relative to October, to 7.6 per cent, reflecting the better-than-expected outturn in the second and third quarters of the fiscal year and sustained strong momentum in the fourth quarter.

"Growth is projected to stay at 6.5 per cent in 2027 (FY2027-28)," it said, while adding that in several South and South-East Asian economies, disruptions in West Asia are expected to reduce tourism and remittance inflows, thereby weakening domestic demand. On inflation, the multilateral body said that it is expected to return to near-target levels after subdued food prices drove a marked decline in 2025 (FY2025-26). This is in line with the RBI's projection. Average retail inflation in FY26 slowed to 2.1 per cent from 4.6 per cent of FY25.

In its recent policy announcement, the RBI said that the ongoing conflict has led to large volatility in international energy and other commodity prices imparting considerable uncertainty to the near-term inflation outlook. The pass-through of higher global energy prices has resulted in price increases in select fuels such as premium petrol and LPG and diesel for industrial use.

On the other hand, the near-term food supply prospects have been boosted by robust *rabi* crop providing some comfort. Considering all these factors, CPI inflation for 2026-27 is projected to be at 4.6 per cent. Persistently-elevated energy prices due to the West Asia conflict and possible *El Nino* conditions (which could have a negative impact on South-West monsoon) pose upside risks to inflation. "Core inflation is projected at 4.4 per cent for 2026-27 and, excluding precious metals, it is even lower indicating that underlying inflation pressures are expected to remain contained," it said.

GLOBAL GROWTH

According to the IMF, global growth is projected to be 3.1 per cent in 2026 and 3.2 per cent in 2027, slower than the recent pace of about 3.4 per cent in 2024-25, and to settle at about that rate in the medium term, slower than its historical (2000-19) average of 3.7 per cent.

"The forecast for 2026 is revised downward by 0.2 percentage point and that for 2027 is unchanged, compared with that in the January 2026 WEO update," the IMF said, while adding that global headline inflation is expected to increase to 4.4 per cent in 2026 and decline to 3.7 per cent in 2027, marking upward revisions for both years.

Russian crude oil imports rebound in March as PSU refiners lift record volumes

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Crude oil imports from Russia surged in March, on a monthly basis, as State-run refiners more than doubled their purchases of the geopolitically sensitive commodity from Moscow.

According to the Finland-based Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), Russia is heavily reliant on Asian markets to sell its oil with 90 per cent of its total exports of crude oil delivered to China and India in the first quarter of 2026.

"India's imports of Russian crude oil doubled month-on-month (m-o-m). The biggest shift was in State-owned refineries' imports from Russia, which saw a massive 148 per cent increase (m-o-m), presumably due to Russian barrels being more available in the spot market, which serve as their primary source of imports," CREA pointed out.

According to global real time data and analytics provider Kpler, India roughly imported around 1.98 mb/d of crude oil from Russia in March compared to around 1 mb/d in February 2026.

India was the second-highest buyer of Russian fossil fuels in March 2026, importing a total of €5.8 billion of Russian hydrocarbons. Crude oil products constituted 91 per cent of India's purchases, totalling €5.3 billion. Coal (€337 million) and oil products (€178.5 million) constituted the remainder of their monthly imports, CREA said.

CRUDE IMPORTS DIP

While India's total crude imports recorded a 4 per cent m-o-m reduction in March 2026, Russian imports doubled. The biggest shift was in State-owned refineries' imports from Russia. Their imports were, in fact, 72 per cent higher than March 2025, presumably due to Russian barrels being more available in the spot market, which serves as the primary source of imports for them, it added.

The State-owned New Mangalore (Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals) and Visakhapatnam (Hindustan Petroleum Corporation) refineries had stopped Russian imports at the end of November 2025, but purchases resumed in March 2026. Private refineries, meanwhile, registered a more modest 66 per cent m-o-m increase, but remained lower than the same time last year, it said.

Despite the EU's ban on imports of oil products made from Russian crude on January 21, 2026, 14 shipments of oil products from refineries, including Indian, have unloaded at EU ports in March, CREA said.

Expert opinion divided over impact of below-normal monsoon on food inflation

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With the IMD's forecasts for below-normal rainfall, the debate on retail food inflation has begun. This year's situation is more critical, with a heatwave, energy price shocks and issues related to fertilisers also expected to play a key role in food prices. However, economic research appears to be divided on the impact of lower-than-normal rainfall on food inflation.

While the Indian Metrological Department (IMD) has pegged the 2026 monsoon at 92 per cent of the Long Period Average (LPA), with a model error margin of ℗5 per cent, private forecaster Skymet has projected rainfall at 94 per cent of LPA, also with a ℗5 per cent margin. This places the season firmly in the "below-normal" category; a normal monsoon is defined as rainfall between 96 per cent and 104 per cent of the LPA. As Indian farmers are largely dependent on the South-West Monsoon for irrigation, a below-normal monsoon has added to the worries.

The possibility of lower productivity due to various factors, including a below-normal monsoon, will have an impact on food inflation and that will, in turn, push headline inflation. While the share of Food & Beverages (F&B) has declined in the new series (base year 2024), it remains the largest component of the CPI basket. The share in the previous series (base year 2012) was 45.86 per cent, against 36.75 per cent now.

Rainfall LPA vs food inflation

	Deviation from LPO (in %)	Food inflation (in %)	Food grain production (000 tonnes)
2017-18	95	7	2,85,010
2018-19	91	0	2,85,210
2019-20	110	1	2,97,500
2020-21	109	3	3,10,740
2021-22	99	9	3,15,616
2022-23	106	3	3,29,687
2023-24	94	8	3,32,298
2024-25	107	8	3,57,732
2025-26	108	(-)1	3,48,657
2026-27	92*	5-5.5#	TBA

*IMD Forecast, #SBI Forecast Source: SBI research, IMD

FOOD PRICE OUTLOOK

Crisil said that in the coming months, while a low base will perk up food inflation, the adverse impact of heatwaves and increased risk from a below-normal South-West monsoon assign an upside to food inflation.

Nomura said while inflation has a patchy relationship with monsoon levels, an overly hot Summer and subnormal rains could impact agricultural output and pose an upside risk to food prices. "Potential shortages of fertilisers could increase input costs for farmers, even as prices are considerably subsidised by the government. Rising commodity prices could further add to imported food inflation, especially in items such as edible oils, where India is a net importer," the agency said, while adding that lower demand from restaurants and households coping with LPG shortages could temper some of the inflationary pressures. "We expect a gradual uptick in F&B inflation from 3 per cent in Q1 to close to 6 per cent by Q4," it said.

However, SBI Research has a slightly different take. Historical patterns suggest that the relationship (below-normal monsoon and food inflation) is not linear. "Years with relatively comfortable rainfall have witnessed elevated food inflation such as 98 per cent rainfall with 8.43 per cent food inflation in FY09, 102 per cent with 15.2 per cent in FY11, while weaker rainfall years such as 93 per cent (FY13) and 91 per cent (FY19) were associated with much lower food inflation of 6.3 per cent and 0.09 per cent, respectively," it said.

Further, it emphasised that the implication is that the all-India monsoon average, by itself, is an insufficient guide to the food price outlook. What matters more is the spatial distribution of rainfall across major crop-producing regions and its timing during the sowing and crop-development phases.

CHENNAI
businessline.
WEDNESDAY - APRIL 15 - 2026

the hindu businessline.
WEDNESDAY - APRIL 15, 2026

Cyber insecurity

RBI suggests viable solutions for digital fraud

The exponential rise in digital transactions, principally UPI in volume terms, has been accompanied by a spike in scams. Unsuspecting, fearful or preoccupied individuals may lose thousands or lakhs of rupees in minutes, or crores over days of "digital arrest". Those who are just curious or looking to make a quick buck can be trapped by clicking on 'phishing' links, apps, videos or messages, which cannibalise their phones or laptops.

They could end up funnelling money into 'mule accounts' used for dubious activity and get criminally implicated. According to a recent discussion paper by the Reserve Bank of India on digital frauds, the number of such events rose from 2.6 lakh in 2021 to 28 lakh in 2025 and amounts involved from ₹551 crore to ₹22,931 crore. This rise in digital heists calls for action at various levels: software protection; a governance system in banks that tackles such fraud with a sense of accountability; heightened public awareness; and a law and order machinery that keeps up with cyber crime methods. The RBI has been engaged with the first two aspects. A master circular issued two years back spells out the systems that must be in place in banks.

The RBI discussion paper contemplates changes in the user software to enhance protection. It suggests a short delay in the execution of the debit — an hour's gap — to give the payer a chance to reconsider the transaction, and reflect on whether he has been defrauded. The paper suggests applying this check on transactions exceeding ₹10,000. According to the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, transactions above ₹10,000 account for about 45 per cent of reported fraud cases by volume, which makes it a good cut-off point. The suggestion is useful, but can apply to P2P transactions, and not P2M ones, where speed is of the essence. It is reasonable to focus on UPI to curb fraud, as it transfers funds instantaneously. UPI also accounts over 80 per cent of all transactions.

Another noteworthy suggestion pertains to third party verification to prevent senior citizens from losing their money. A trusted person identified by a vulnerable customer can act as another layer of authentication for transactions above ₹50,000. The paper suggests that P2Ms, which includes routine debits, can be exempted from this requirement — which holds true for the proposed one-hour norm as well. As for identifying mule accounts, the RBI has suggested an annual credit limit of ₹25 lakh annually for low turnover credit accounts, beyond which banks should sit up and take notice. But investigations can turn messy, as accounts of innocent consumers are frozen. An investigation protocol needs to evolve for cyber fraud. While the police is developing its capacities, it is behind the curve. The RBI should periodically review IT governance in banks, and their interface with the police. Finally, consumer awareness campaigns matter the most. Cyber crime works as much on manipulating the mind, as it does on software.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH

How India is funding Silicon Valley's rise

THE GREAT DRAIN. Every time we use AI, we add to a hidden "Token Tax" that drains value from India's economy

GETTY IMAGES

NISHANT SAHDEV

Silicon Valley's earnings calls are already answering the most important question about artificial intelligence: where the money ends up. There's an undeniable sense of triumph in India's tech ecosystem right now, but we might be celebrating a digital victory we haven't actually won.

If you look across the country, the physical transformation is staggering. We are investing massive capital in hyper-scale data centre parks in Navi Mumbai. Legacy IT giants are weaving AI into enterprise networks and digital public infrastructure. The government has stepped in to subsidise tens of thousands of GPUs (graphics processing units) for startups. We are doing everything right on the hardware front.

But beneath the ribbon-cutting and the applause lies an uncomfortable economic reality: India's much-hyped AI boom is directly funding Silicon Valley.

In effect, we have signed up for a "Token Tax". Every single time a developer in Bengaluru uses an AI coding assistant, or an e-commerce app personalises a shopping feed, or a local bank automates a customer query in Hindi, a micro-payment leaves the country. We are pouring concrete, laying the fibre-optic cables, and buying the servers. But the actual intelligence — the cognitive engine running on top of all that infrastructure — remains foreign-owned.

We are building the toll roads, but someone else is collecting the toll.

You can already see this imbalance playing out on global balance sheets. While we celebrate our domestic infrastructure push, HSBC projects that the world's leading tech giants will pull in $2.8 trillion in revenue by 2026. A rapidly growing share of that wealth is being extracted from countries exactly like ours — markets that are adopting AI at breakneck speed, but failing to own the underlying models. The global cloud monopolies aren't threatened by our large-scale hardware investments; they are banking on them.

THE PERPETUAL UTILITY BILL

To understand how we got trapped here, you have to look at how the fundamental business model of software has shifted.

Back in the 2000s, Indian IT firms operated in a world of ownership. You bought a database licence, installed it on your servers, and built an empire of high-margin services on top of it. It was a one-time capital expense. You owned the tool. That era is over. Today, AI is metered. You rent it by the token.

Indian companies are doing the hardest, most unglamorous work in the digital economy: acquiring price-sensitive users, navigating complex local regulations, and structuring messy domestic data. Yet the highest-margin layer of the entire value chain — the API fee for the intelligence itself — flows immediately outward. India is no longer just exporting software services. We are importing intelligence, one API call at a time.

MATH DOESN'T WORK AT SCALE

The usual pushback I hear from tech leaders is predictable: Why not just rent? Renting a frontier model from a US tech giant is infinitely faster, highly reliable, and cheaper than spending billions to train our own. Why not just focus on building great local apps and let California handle the heavy lifting?

The answer is simple: that model mathematically cannot survive Indian economics.

Our market is defined by enormous volume but incredibly tight margins.

> **For three decades, India exported human talent to power the global digital economy. But in** the generative AI era, selling human effort is a depreciating asset

The average revenue per user (ARPU) here is a fraction of what companies earn in the West. You simply cannot serve hundreds of millions of users while paying a dollar-denominated, per-token tax to Silicon Valley for every interaction.

Consider an agri-tech startup offering AI-driven crop advice to farmers in Marathi for a ₹50 monthly subscription. If every complex question that farmer asks requires a round-trip to a foreign AI model costing a few cents, the math collapses. The more successful the product becomes, the more money it bleeds.

This is why so many brilliant Indian AI startups are currently stuck in "pilot purgatory". The product works, the local demand is real, but scaling it destroys their balance sheet. That isn't a healthy tech ecosystem. It is a dependency loop.

A UPI-STYLE PLAYBOOK FOR AI

The solution isn't some blindly idealistic push to build everything domestically at any cost. Trying to create a bloated, state-run 'National AI Reserve' will likely just give us a slow, bureaucratic system that the private sector ignores.

But we have navigated this exact kind of trap before. Look at digital payments. A decade ago, India flat-out refused to hand over its payment infrastructure to global incumbents like Visa and Mastercard. We built the Unified Payments Interface (UPI). India built the digital rails, retained ownership of the core system, and let private companies innovate on top of it. We desperately need a similar playbook for AI.

The government's role shouldn't be to build the models, but to underwrite the immense compute required for a consortium of private Indian firms, researchers, and startups to develop competitive, sovereign models.

Simultaneously, corporate India needs to wake up. Not every internal workflow or document-processing task requires pinging a massive, trillion-parameter global model. Enterprises need to pivot towards Small Language Models (SLMs) that can be trained on their own proprietary data and run safely on local servers. This keeps costs down, protects privacy, and entirely cuts the external gatekeepers out of the transaction.

In this new era, data gravity — keeping your data and computation local — is the only real defence against algorithmic rent.

THE INVISIBLE DEFICIT

We obsessively track our trade deficit when it comes to oil, gold, and electronics. We know exactly what physical imports cost our economy. But we are completely blind to our "Compute Deficit".

India spends roughly $130 billion a year importing oil. If our digital adoption continues on this path, the cost of relying on foreign AI APIs could eventually rival that scale. Millions of daily API calls are already draining capital out of the country, yet this massive outflow is practically invisible in our national accounting.

For three decades, India exported human talent to power the global digital economy. But in the generative AI era, selling human effort is a depreciating asset. Intelligence itself is becoming the commodity, and right now, we don't own it.

Globally, other nations are waking up. France is heavily backing Mistral to ensure European sovereignty. The UAE is pouring billions into the Falcon models. China has insulated its entire ecosystem. India risks becoming the only major digital economy that defaults to pure import for its cognitive engine.

India now faces a clear choice. We can continue subsidising hardware and exporting the profits, settling for scale without ownership. Or, we can do the harder work of shifting from adoption to control. Because the arithmetic is unforgiving. If nothing changes, by 2030, India's most expensive import won't be Arabian oil or Chinese electronics. It will be intelligence. And we won't just be buying it — we will be renting our own future.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure, and global systems

West-Asia war could reshape the AI race

As AI is energy hungry and requires new tech infrastructure, developing nations will find it harder in the current milieu

bl. explainer

Soorya Narayanan SV

The Iran-Israel-US war comes at a time when artificial intelligence is emerging as one of the biggest energy consumers of the decade. As AI spreads across every sector of human activity, the global race to scale it collides with a highly volatile force: geopolitics. This convergence exposes how dependent technology is on physical resources.

How will the disruption in energy supply impact AI adoption?

Gas-fired power stations are the largest source of power for US data centres, data from the International Energy Agency (IEA) shows. As energy markets tighten and wealthier nations and big tech companies get long term access to more energy, through renewable capacity and long-term contracts, the constraints become sharper for developing economies which would lead to higher electricity costs, limited grid capacity and reduced access to advanced computing infrastructure.

How does conflict widen inequality in AI development

The ability to build and scale intelligence is directly proportional to access to affordable and reliable power. What was once a digital gap in the internet era could evolve to structural inequality. AI, despite being "digital," is deeply physical: it runs on electricity, infrastructure, rare minerals, and capital. When energy becomes scarce or expensive, the consequences ripple unevenly. Over time, this rebalancing may reshape the AI value chain, concentrating control not just over technology, but over the economics of intelligence itself.

How will the funding for AI companies be impacted by the war?

UNCTAD data suggests that Strait of Hormuz disruption could lead to falling stock prices, weakening currencies, and rising cost of external debt for developing countries. This will reduce the investable surplus for global investors.

DATA CENTRES. Require huge amounts of energy ISTOCKPHOTO

Global uncertainty linked to the crisis is pushing capital towards safer bets such as the US dollar, defensive stocks, and reducing flow into emerging markets. Expansion plans into Gulf markets, once seen as a natural growth corridor for tech startups, are also facing operational challenges as geopolitical instability is affecting investor sentiment.

There is a deeper shift underway. EY report shows that between January and September 2025, sovereign wealth funds were involved in AI venture transactions totalling $46 billion. Sovereign wealth funds in West Asia, among the most active investors in global technology, may temporarily redirect capital towards energy security and defence. For startups reliant on long-term funding, this reallocation could tighten liquidity just as AI infra and development costs are rising due to the geopolitical tensions.

How is war straining the foundations of AI?

The current developments point to the convergence of multiple stress points. Energy markets are shifting; supply chains are tightening, changing investor sentiments and shifting capital flows. AI is exposed to all these factors and unlike the earlier tech developments, AI is energy hungry, requires new tech infrastructure, and each of these factors is being tested by the unfolding crisis.

Disruptions in Qatar's gas ecosystem are fuelling concerns over helium supply — a vital input for semiconductor manufacturing and advanced cooling technologies. Meanwhile, tensions around the Strait of Hormuz are likely to drive energy costs for chipmakers worldwide.

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Where is the UN?

The US-Iran war has occupied the front pages of newspapers as well as prime slots in the electronic media. Many national leaders have been figured prominently. However, one surprising absence is of the United Nations and its leadership.

One would have expected the UN to be putting out messages for peace and avoidance of hostilities while also making attempts to mobilise relief and at mediation between the warring parties.

But none of this has happened. This is a major lapse because unlike a dispute between two parties, this war involves almost every country in the world given the disruption in oil and gas supplies from West Asia.

The complete absence of the UN from this West Asia crisis could lead to growing marginalisation of the world's premier multilateral agency.

One hopes this does not happen.

V Vijaykumar
Pune

Rupee volatility

Apropos 'Pressure point' (April 14), the rupee's recent turbulence underscores the delicate balance between intervention and market autonomy. The RBI's crackdown on speculative trades has offered short-term relief, yet history reminds us that such measures rarely secure lasting stability. Currency strength ultimately depends on fundamentals like crude prices, portfolio flows and investor confidence, not regulatory ceilings.

The lesson is pragmatic: central banks can manage volatility but cannot dictate value. Durable resilience requires structural reforms that bolster exports, attract investment and reduce dependence on volatile energy imports.

India's economic credibility will be judged not by temporary restrictions but by its ability to sustain confidence in the rupee. Policy must therefore move beyond firefighting towards building long-term stability.

K Chidanand Kumar
Bengaluru

Finance capital flows

This refers to 'Finance capital in time of war' (April 14). The article makes a counter-intuitive but well-supported observation — finance capital has not followed the war machine as conventional wisdom would suggest. Defence stocks declining despite rising demand, and capital moving towards oil speculation instead, reveal how unpredictable conflict-driven markets actually are. For investors, the key takeaway is that war-related opportunities rarely materialise as cleanly as anticipated.

M Barathi
Bengaluru

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M CH-CHE

Continuity via status quo

The nuts and bolts of succession planning

R Anand

A recent appointment of a senior professional manager of a large and reputed public listed NBFC as Joint Managing Director for a period of four years effective April 1 has raised interesting issues on continuity by status quo as against a normal succession planning by identifying the right person for that slot.

While the latter approach is widely accepted as the best practice by management gurus, regulators retaining existing talent subject to merit is also an accepted norm.

This appointment raised eyebrows because the person in question is 67 years and has been elevated (not redesignated) as JMD from DMD.

He would be 71 by the time he completes his four-year term.

Age is just a number and should not be confused with competence or capabilities.

Age should not be a factor in judging someone's competence or capability.

The only question that arises here is whether there is nobody else available to fill up the slot.

A survey across public listed companies shows that there are only a few cases where a professional manager in a family owned listed company has been promoted/elevated in a whole time Director position above the age of 65 years.

SHAREHOLDERS' VOTE

The fact that the shareholders have voted in overwhelming majority to this elevation is enough testimony to the merits of the case and the capability of the individual.

The moot point is — whether a rare phenomenon like this needs a more detailed justification from the perspective of succession planning.

Understanding how the Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC) of the Board brainstormed this recommendation and the manner in which it was captured in the minutes as also how the Chairman of NRC briefed the Board and the discussions at the Board on this agenda item would be an important lesson to learn.

A cynic would remark that most NRCs are at best a pass through vehicle particularly in family owned companies.

Considering the pedigree of the company in question this appointment would have surely passed all the tests of both form

TOP HONCHOS. Setting the norms ISTOCKPHOTO

and substance with robust and foolproof documentation.

RBI'S VIEW

Regulators in the recent past have voiced concerns over succession planning more in the context of risk mitigation.

Audit and Risk Management Committees are getting more vocal about the No 2 person of every top management person being part of the presentations and deliberations.

There is no stand alone RBI circular on "Succession planning for NBFCs".

Instead the requirements are spelt out in various guidelines issued in 2023 and 2025.

The crux as laid out by the regulator is that — for the middle and upper layer NBFCs boards are responsible for "orderly succession at Board and Senior Management level". These guidelines also emphasise structured management continuity in financial entities.

We live in times where board responsibilities and duties are getting onerous.

GOVERNANCE NORMS

Regulators like SEBI, RBI and in the recent times NFRA have raised the standards of overall governance across companies.

The subject of succession planning has now gradually moved from management school discussions to 'on-the-ground' implementation.

The unusual case discussed here should ideally be analysed threadbare to serve as a lesson for similar cases that come up in future.

For connoisseurs of Bridge — a fascinating card game — every deal is distinct and different. Likewise every board meeting throws up something new and different particularly for independent directors.

The writer is a Chartered Accountant

JIM O'NEILL

Iran war, a boon for the BRICS

LOOK EAST. This war will result in a shift of geostrategic balance to the East, benefitting counties like China and India

GETTY IMAGES

With the US and Iran agreeing to a two-week ceasefire, many are using this pause to wonder what, if anything, would allow US President Donald Trump to declare victory and end the fighting. One necessary condition, it seems, is the permanent reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, through which around one-fifth of the global oil supply flows. But even with the ceasefire temporarily reopening the Strait, Trump has not secured lasting stability for shipping. Of course, had Trump simply refrained from attacking Iran in the first place, the Strait never would have been closed.

The first month of the war delivered several other lessons. One concerns the Israeli leadership's thinking. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu knew that he could get Trump's attention by presenting him with the prospect of a big, showy victory, and that this US administration would not pause to consider the second- or third-order consequences. Perhaps it was merely a coincidence that the strikes on Iran came soon after the US Supreme Court struck down Trump's International Emergency Economic Powers Act tariffs, but perhaps not.

The apparent lack of US strategic planning points to a second lesson: The Gulf states' trust in US security guarantees may not have been justified. While some leaders are quietly hoping that the war will still lead to a dramatic, positive change in Iran, hope is not a strategy — and their desired outcome looks increasingly unrealistic. The Iranian regime has already shown that there is no line it will not cross to ensure its survival and deter its enemies.

EASTWARD TILT

That is why it is hard to avoid the conclusion that this conflict will shift the region's strategic balance eastward, toward rising powers like China and India. Along with Russia, both are central players in the BRICS+, which now includes Iran, and which has an opportunity to present itself as an inevitable leader of whatever new global order is emerging.

China is especially likely to play an important role in whatever follows from the war. Both it and Russia were almost certainly behind the push to include Iran in the BRICS's expanded membership. At the same time, India will host the next BRICS+ summit this September, and it is relishing its newfound role as the de facto champion of the Global South, owing to its central geographic position in the 21st-century economy and its massive population.

Of course, India's relationships with its immediate neighbours remain complicated. But even longstanding historical tensions are not

> **Along with Russia, China and India are central players in the BRICS+, which now includes Iran, and which has an** opportunity to present itself as an inevitable leader of whatever new global order is emerging

deal-breakers. As Heiwai Tang and Brian Wong Yue Shun show in their edited volume *Towards a Future for BRICS+*, India has a strong interest in mining the potential for mutual benefits within the bloc. A top concern is access to Middle Eastern energy supplies, both for itself and for its neighbours.

Asian economies have been hit especially hard by both the energy price shock and the supply shortfall, and Iran knows that. Occasional statements over the past month suggest that Iran would welcome pricing oil destined for friendly countries in renminbi. These dynamics are even more pertinent in light of the increased role that Pakistan has played as a mediator between the US and Iran. If the Pakistanis help bring the energy crisis to a close, not even India could complain.

ADVANTAGE CHINA

The war, if it continues, also has obvious implications for Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping's planned bilateral meeting, which has been rescheduled for mid-May.

Whenever it does take place, Xi will probably feel that China has a strong hand, not only to apply leverage on Iran but also to drive a hard bargain with the US. Markets will be watching closely for any hints of possible developments ahead of the summit.

Given these converging forces, the rising efficiency of oil consumption, and the ongoing increase in alternative energy sources, this crisis is unlikely to cause as much market turmoil as the 2008 financial crisis, the arrival of Covid-19, or the 2022 Russian invasion of Ukraine.

After all, Trump cannot afford to preside over rapidly rising gas prices as Americans head into their peak driving season — and then head to the polls for the midterm elections coming in November. His increasingly unhinged social-media posts suggest that he is beyond frustrated with the situation and desperate for an off-ramp. If the ceasefire doesn't provide him with one, China may have a potential trump card.

The writer is a former UK Treasury minister and a former chairman of Goldman Sachs Asset Management. Copyright: Project Syndicate, 2026.

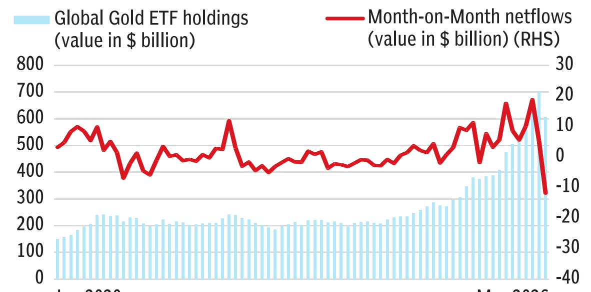
STATISTALK.

Compiled **Dhuraivel Gunasekaran** | Graphic **Visweswaran V**

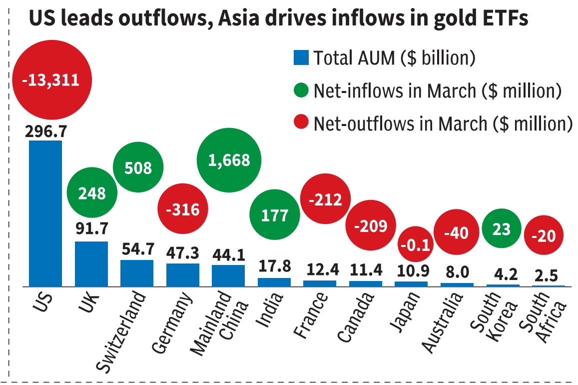
Global gold ETFs post worst-ever $12bn monthly outflow: WGC

Global gold ETFs witnessed an unprecedented $12 billion outflow in March 2026, marking the steepest monthly decline on record, largely due to heavy selling by North American investors, according to the World Gold Council. Assets under management stood at $606 billion as of March 2026. North America recorded sharp outflows as rising bond yields, a stronger dollar and risk-off sentiment prompted investors to exit gold ETFs. Europe saw modest outflows, tracking price declines and higher yields. In contrast, Asia continued to see strong inflows, led by China and supported by India, driven by safe-haven demand, weaker local markets and currency pressures. Key facts:

Global Gold ETFs see steepest-ever monthly outflows in March



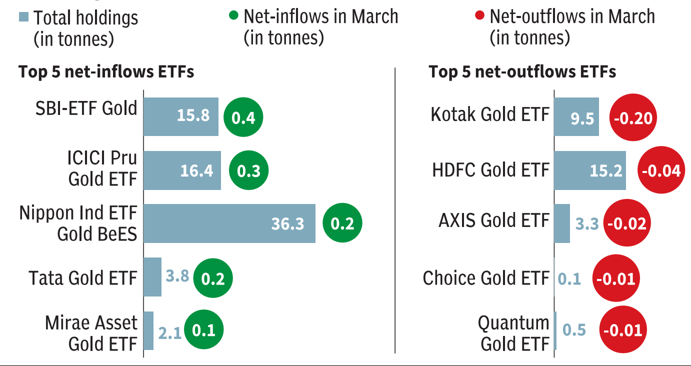
US leads outflows, Asia drives inflows in gold ETFs



Global ETF giants see outflows

	Total holdings (in tonnes)	Net-flows in March ($ million)
Top 3 net-inflows ETFs		
Huaan Yifu Gold ETF	111	637
WisdomTree Core Physical Gold	14	347
E Fund Gold Tradable OE Sec	41	305
Top 3 net-outflows ETFs		
SPDR Gold Shares	1,047	-8,427
iShares Gold Trust	476	-3,678
Sprott Physical Gold Trust	115	-467

Indian gold ETFs see mild inflows amid limited outflows



Source: World gold council

On businessline.in

Assessing the easing of provisioning norms by RBI

The pre-emptive regulatory measures appear largely cosmetic. They mask risks within the capital framework rather than addressing underlying structural issues, argues **Dhananjay Sinha**

https://tinyurl.com/383n7r6h

Iran war, a test for India's economic resilience

India has shown remarkable agility and economic resilience, built in the past decade through sound macroeconomic policies, **Abhinav Jindal** and **Tarunika Jain Agarwal** point out

https://tinyurl.com/uwwbu93

Iran war's impact on India's farm output and food inflation

There is an urgent need to ramp up domestic fertilizer production and nudge the use of organic and bio-fertilizers, say **A Amarender Reddy** and **Tulsi Lingareddy**

https://tinyurl.com/2nwxhkcs

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 15, 2006

Chennai, Kolkata airport revamp to cost Rs 7,000 cr

The modernisation of Chennai and Kolkata air ports may be out of the reach of the Airports Authority of India (AAI). Official sources told Business Line that despite having reserves and surplus to the tune of Rs 3,352 crore (provisional) as of April 1 this year, the Authority would not be able to touch the special reserves as that is earmarked for specified expenditure.

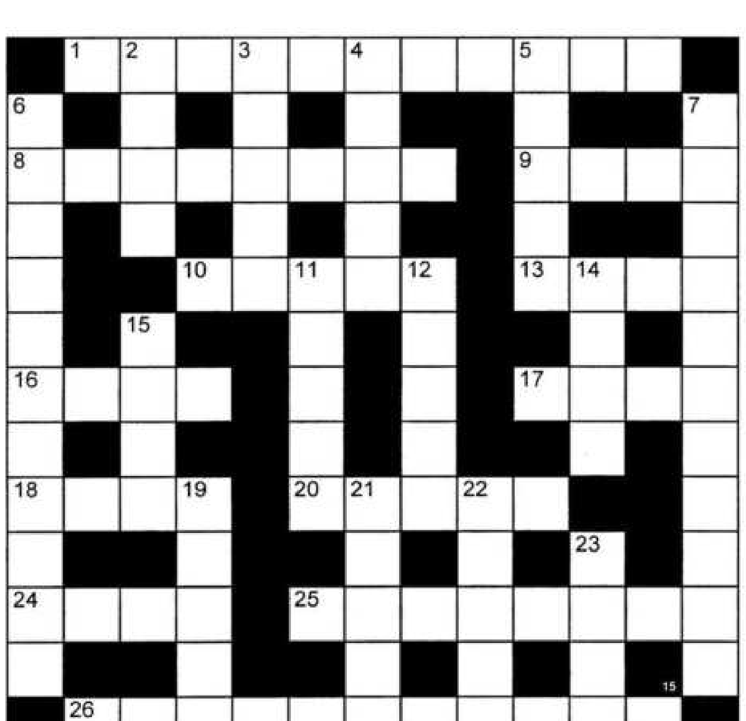
SAIF outlines major investment plans

Private equity firm SAIF Partners, which has till now invested about $100 million in India, is planning to scale up its investments in the country in a big way. According to Mr Ravi Adusumalli, General Partner, Head of India Operations, SAIF Partners, the firm is scouting for buys across sectors including media and auto components and is in the process of setting up a third fund of about $ 800 million.

On radar, tapping atomic energy for potable water

The Indo-US nuclear deal seems to have given a fresh impetus to the use of atomic energy in a host of civilian sectors, including tackling the growing drinking water shortage. The Government has launched an atomic energy-based 'action plan' to solve the future drinking water problem by converting seawater into potable water.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2658



EASY

ACROSS

01. Secrecy, disguise (11)
08. Come up with; move past (8)
09. Festivity, sporting occasion (4)
10. Flood, extinguish (5)
13. Hindu woman's garment (4)
16. Rope supporting mast (4)
17. A sign (4)
18. Copies; anthropoids (4)
20. Proficient, skilled (5)
24. Head of land running into the sea (4)
25. Testimony (8)
26. Vehicle display of registration (6-5)

DOWN

02. Bovine creatures (4)
03. Provide food, entertainment (5)
04. Awry, at an oblique angle (5)
05. Moves gradually sideways (5)
06. Hobby-horse entertainment (6-5)
07. Puppets on strings (11)
11. 'Grand' entertainment (5)
12. Look after the sick (5)
14. Host, great number (4)
15. Naked (4)
19. Water vapour (5)
21. Bird such as loon (5)
22. Foot-lever (5)
23. Draw together, unite closely (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

01. Connect male with this sort of hiding (11)
08. Move out and pass to appear greedy (8)
09. Los Angeles follows State on festive occasion (4)
10. Suffer from over-watering, as a medical man will admit (5)
13. Garment from the South, a right one in the East (4)
16. The support that will not leave one (4)
17. A sign of mendacity encourages nervous leaders (4)
18. Mimics physical education as it's outside (4)
20. Likely, when about half-dead, to be skilful (5)
24. Good Hope of its not being capitalised as sleeveless cloak (4)
25. Proof of vice might need to be distributed (8)
26. Belt up, taking right name out for vehicular identification (6-5)

DOWN

02. One has ten different animals (4)
03. Provide the food for Tibert with hesitation (5)
04. On a slant like the Botanical Gardens (5)
05. Gradually moves to the Borders (5)
06. Romans cried out for entertainment in May (6-5)
07. Tories, men at variance dancing when strings are pulled (11)
11. Stage work works in Ancient Rome (5)
12. She's working onwards when separated (5)
14. The old host is revealed in popular mythology (4)
15. Having nothing on, be around half of the year (4)
19. Vapour trail starts in the main at end of slipstream (5)
21. One who will be in over his head when at work (5)
22. Put one's foot down, and it will work (5)
23. Do so to one's brows in woolly thinking? (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2657

ACROSS 1. Heritable 5. Cot 7. Tome 8. Training 10. Handicap 11. Spot 13. Dimmer 15. Bolero 18. Cane 19. Vertical 22. Episodic 23. Safe 24. Pan 25. Forgetful

DOWN 1. Hitched 2. Roman 3. Burlap 4. Evil 5. Cripple 6. Tight 9. Diver 12. Mouth 14. Mention 16. Oil well 17. Senior 18. Cheap 20. Chaff 21. Roof

QUICKLY.

Srijesh Kumar is Practo's Global CPTO

Bengaluru: Practo announced the appointment of Srijesh Kumar as its Global Chief Product and Technology Officer (CPTO). Srijesh will lead Practo's product and technology teams end-to-end, as it scales across global markets to enhance patient and provider experiences. His appointment comes at a time when the company is preparing for its IPO. OUR BUREAU

Poonawalla Fincorp mops up ₹2,500 cr via QIP

Mumbai: Poonawalla Fincorp Ltd has raised ₹2,500 crore via a Qualified Institutions Placement (QIP) at ₹370.75 per share, or a 5 per cent discount to the floor price of ₹390.26/share. The Cyrus Poonawalla Group promoted non-deposit taking systemically important non-banking finance company (ND-SI-NBFC) issued 67,430,883 equity shares of face value ₹2 each to QIBs. OUR BUREAU

5 jewellery firms defer IPO plans amid bearish market

AT ODDS. Mismatch seen between promoter valuation expectations and investor appetite

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

SHEEN OFF? Gold prices are entering a phase of consolidation alongside overall equity market weakness REUTERS

Plans by five jewellery companies to hit the market with initial public offers (IPOs) worth ₹3,840 crore have been delayed, as weak market conditions and bearish sentiment in the primary market are holding back new issuances.

Listing on the exchanges will drive tangible business benefits, including strengthening brand trust, enhancing customer and supplier confidence and supporting organised expansion for jewellery companies.

In fact, most of the listed jewellery companies have delivered better returns to investors as the sharp rise in gold prices boosted their revenue despite subdued demand.

IN THE PIPELINE

Among the most-awaited, Lalithaa Jewellery Mart plans to raise ₹1,700 crore, and the issuance was approved by SEBI last October. The Chennai-based company's offer includes a fresh equity issuance of ₹1,200 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of ₹500 crore by its promoter Kiran Kumar Jain.

The integrated gold platform, Augmont Enterprises, received SEBI approval in January to raise ₹800 crore. The IPO has on offer fresh equity issuance of ₹620 crore and OFS of ₹180 crore by existing investors.

Priority Jewels received SEBI approval last August to mop up ₹540 crore and raised ₹16 crore as pre-IPO placement in February.

Similarly, the Mumbai-based gold jewellery manufacturers, Shankesh Jewellers and Sunil Gold, plan to raise ₹400 crore each through IPOs. While Shankesh Jewellers received SEBI's nod in February, Sunil Gold, which filed its DRHP in mid-March, is awaiting the final SEBI nod.

MARKET OUTLOOK

Ratiraj Tibrewal, CEO, Choice Capital, said that despite strong earlier listings by jewellery companies, recent IPO delays indicate a broader market reset.

Gold prices are entering a phase of consolidation alongside overall equity market weakness, even as leading jewellery stocks remain relatively resilient, he said.

Meanwhile, a mismatch between promoter valuation expectations and investor appetite, coupled with cautious institutional participation and tighter liquidity, is leading companies to defer launches despite SEBI approval, he added.

VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, said jewellery companies have been doing well even in a weak market, as the industry's prospects are bright.

The success of IPOs in this segment will depend on the quality of management and the valuation of the stocks, he said. Dr Ravi Singh, Chief Research Officer, Master Capital Services, said the hesitation of jewellery companies stems less from any fundamental weakness in the sector and more from the prevailing sentiment in the secondary market.

Listed jewellery players, such as Titan, Kalyan Jewellers, PN Gadgil Jewellers and Senco Gold, have reported healthy earnings and consumer demand remaining structurally intact, he added.

₹ eyes recovery as dollar weakens

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl Research Bureau

The rupee weakened over the last week, declining nearly 0.6 per cent to close at 93.38 against the dollar on Monday. Domestic markets remained shut on Tuesday. The local currency continues to face pressure as key supportive factors fade.

Earlier, the rupee had found some support from banks unwinding dollar positions to comply with the RBI's cap on Net Open Position (NOP-INR). However, with the April 10 deadline now behind, this source of support is unlikely to persist. Foreign flows remain a concern. According to NSDL data, net FPI outflows stood at about $1.1 billion over the past week and $6.5 billion so far in April, reflecting continued investor caution. Geopolitical tensions are also weighing on sentiment. The escalation involving Iran, particularly the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz by the US following failed negotiations, has heightened uncertainty and kept risk appetite subdued.

While these factors have pressured the rupee, the dollar has not gained significant traction. Despite the geopolitical developments, the greenback has remained soft, partly due to concerns over the US economy. Recent data showed the US consumer sentiment index falling sharply to 47.60 in April from 53.30 in March, one of the lowest levels on record. In addition, inflation showed signs of picking up, with CPI rising 0.9 per cent in March.

While both the rupee and the dollar appear weak, relative pressures from geopolitical risks and capital outflows are likely to keep the rupee on the defensive .

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

CHART

The rupee rallied to mark a three-week high of 92.24 last Wednesday. But the local unit reversed the trend and closed at 93.38 on Monday. As the broader trend is bearish, the recent fall off the 92.24 level might indicate that the rupee has resumed the downtrend.

Nevertheless, there is a support ahead at 93.50. If this level is taken out, the Indian currency can fall further to 94. On the other hand, if there is a rally, it can retest 92.24. A breakout of this can lift it to 92, a notable resistance.

The dollar index was down one-third of a per cent on Monday, leading to the breach of a support at 98.70, where the 50-day moving average and the 50 per cent Fibonacci retracement of the previous rally coincides. So, the break down is a significant and the dollar index might remain weak, at least in the near-term.

The nearest notable support for the dollar index is at 98 followed by 97.50. If there is a decline to these levels, the rupee will have room to appreciate, potentially to 92.

The dollar index will gain bullishness only if it reclaims 98.70. If that happens, the rupee can slip to 94.

OUTLOOK

Overall, the rupee may remain under pressure, but the softness in the dollar could limit further downside. In the near term, the local currency may consolidate with a mild recovery bias towards 92.50–92.24. However, a sustained move beyond this is uncertain, and a rebound in the dollar index could push the rupee back towards 93.50–94.

At ₹299.74 lakh crore, UPI processed 228.5 billion transactions in 2025

Asian News International
New Delhi

India's digital payments ecosystem witnessed a transformative year, with the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) processing a staggering 228.5 billion transactions in 2025, marking a 33 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) increase, according to a report by Worldline.

The total transaction value reached ₹299.74 lakh crore, solidifying UPI's position as the default payment method, according to the report, 'India Digital Payments Report — Year 2025 in Review'. The report highlights India's transition to a micro-transaction economy, where digital payments are replacing small-value cash purchases across categories, from neighbourhood retail to transport.

The average ticket size (ATS) of UPI transactions continued to decline, indicating growing use for everyday purchases. Overall, UPI ATS fell 9 per cent to ₹1,314, while merchant payments ATS dropped to ₹592.

PAYMENT BEHAVIOUR

UPI continues to dominate India's payments landscape, with strong growth in both person-to-person (P2P) and person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions. P2M payments rose 34 per cent to 143.82 billion.

Merchant acceptance infrastructure expanded, with UPI QR codes increasing to 731.38 million, up 15 per cent y-o-y, and PoS terminals growing to 11.48 million, up 15 per cent y-o-y.

While UPI dominates everyday payments, card usage continues to grow in high-value and online commerce. Credit card transactions increased 27 per cent to 5.69 billion, while debit card volumes declined 23 per cent, reflecting migration of small-value transactions to UPI, the report said. Online credit card payments reached ₹14.53 lakh crore.

RECURRING PAYMENTS

Recurring digital payments are gaining momentum, with transactions on Bharat BillPay reaching 3.05 billion in 2025, up 40 per cent y-o-y, and ₹14.84 lakh crore in value, up 93 per cent.

The platform is seeing strong adoption across categories such as education fees, insurance payments, EMI repayments, and subscription services, signalling the rise of a "set-and-forget" digital payments model.

Chartered Speed eyes ₹1,900 cr revenue driven by 3,000 e-bus orders

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Chartered Speed is eyeing to more than double its revenues, from under ₹700 crore currently to ₹1,800-1,900 crore over the next two years, powered by a 3,000-electric bus order book under Central government schemes.

The Ahmedabad-based bus fleet operator has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with SEBI to raise ₹855 crore, and is likely to bring its IPO in the second half of FY27.

Once deployed, 3,000 electric buses are expected to generate ₹1,100-1,300 crore in annual revenue.

"Current contracts 1,300 buses under PM e-Bus Seva and 1,700 under PM E-DRIVE will contribute ₹400-500 crore and ₹700-800 crore annually, respectively," said senior industry officials, who attended the company's investor meet recently.

It operates under the gross cost contract (GCC) model, procuring, owning and operating buses for State transport undertakings in exchange for a fixed per-kilometre fee over long-term contracts — offering predictable revenue streams but demanding high upfront capital.

The ₹855-crore IPO comprises a ₹655 crore fresh issue and a ₹200-crore offer-for-sale by promoters Pankaj Gandhi and Alka Pankaj Gandhi. Proceeds will fund electric bus investment (approximately ₹98 crore) and debt repayment of around ₹396.4 crore, with a pre-IPO placement of up to ₹131 crore also under consideration.

Chartered Speed has since grown to over 2,000 buses across multiple states, with around 65 per cent of revenue from government and municipal contracts.

Of the 52,000 buses sanctioned under PM e-Bus Seva (38,000) and PM E-DRIVE (14,000), only around 17,000 have been tendered so far, leaving over 35,000 yet to be bid out. The segment is highly fragmented and most operators run fewer than 300 buses, limiting competition at scale.

Chartered Speed keeps all operations, drivers, maintenance, tyres and cleaning in-house. The company is EBITDA- and PAT-positive.

POLICY SUPPORT, GAPS

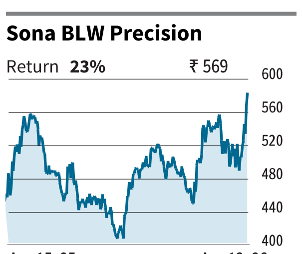
The government's payment security mechanism (PSM), backed by escrow accounts and a central liquidity buffer managed by CESL, has reduced payment risk from State transport undertakings. But execution remains hostage to depot electrification delays and OEM supply backlogs.

The bus sector in India continues to lack formal recognition. This contributes to an increased cost of capital, particularly in instances where project delays occur beyond their control.

TODAY'S PICK.

Sona BLW Precision Forgings (₹569.20): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. Research Bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for Sona BLW Precision Forgings. The stock has risen over 2 per cent on Monday when the broader markets were down.

Indeed, the stock has surged about 9 per cent in the last two trading days. This rise has taken the share price well above a key resistance at ₹540.

This level of ₹540 will now be a good resistance-turned-support. Sona BLW Precision Forgings share price can rise to ₹600-605 in the coming weeks.

Traders can go long now at ₹569. Accumulate on dips at ₹548. Keep the stop-loss at ₹538 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹575 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹581.

Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹582 and ₹590 when the share price touches ₹588 and ₹594, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹600.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23850 » **Nifty 50 Futures**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23750	23680	23980	24000	Go short on a rise at 23960. Keep the stop-loss at 24010

₹793 » **HDFC Bank**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
787	780	802	812	Go short only below 787. Keep the stop-loss at 789

₹1276 » **Infosys**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1265	1240	1290	1305	Take fresh shorts below 1265 with a stop-loss at 1270

₹299 » **ITC**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
298	296	300	302	Go short below 298. Stop-loss can be placed at 299

₹287 » **ONGC**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
285	282	290	293	Go long now and at 286. Keep the stop-loss at 285

₹1314 » **Reliance Ind.**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1310	1290	1335	1350	Go short only below 1310. Keep the stop-loss at 1315

₹1062 » **SBI**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1055	1040	1080	1100	Take fresh longs above 1080 with a stop-loss at 1075

₹2470 » **TCS**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2450	2420	2480	2500	Go short now and on a rise at 2475 with a stop-loss at 2485

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Market volatility hits margin trading activity in March

Our Bureau
Mumbai

OUT OF CONTROL. India's margin trading facility (MTF) book declined for the second consecutive month in March, falling 5.6% amid market volatility and geopolitical uncertainties

The NSE continued to dominate the segment of MTF, accounting for over 95 per cent of total volumes

A sustained bout of market volatility is beginning to dent leveraged participation, with India's margin trading facility (MTF) book declining for the second consecutive month in March.

The MTF book fell 5.6 per cent month-on-month (m-o-m) to a total average of ₹1.13 lakh crore in March, following a marginal 0.5 per cent decline in February and a 3 per cent rise in January, according to CareEdge.

"The moderation likely reflects weaker market conditions, elevated volatility, and geopolitical uncertainties, which led to a more cautious approach and some pullback in leveraged positions," the report said.

STRONG GROWTH

Despite the sequential decline, the MTF book grew 57.1 per cent year-on-year in March to ₹1.13 lakh crore, reflecting sustained retail participation and continued interest in leveraged equity exposure.

The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) continued to dominate the segment, accounting for over 95 per cent of total MTF volumes.

Its MTF book stood at ₹1.09 lakh crore in March, up 58.6 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y), though it saw a sequential dip.

ROBUST ACTIVITY

In comparison, BSE Limited reported a smaller MTF book, which grew 23.7 per cent annually but declined marginally m-o-m.

Overall market activity remained robust despite the dip in leveraged activity. Average daily turnover (ADTO) across equity and derivatives rose 46.5 per cent y-o-y to ₹517.7 lakh crore in March.

Sequentially, ADTO also increased, driven by year-end trading activity such as portfolio rebalancing, tax-related trades and derivatives expiry-led rollover and unwinding of positions.

Cash market turnover, too, improved, rising 28.9 per cent y-o-y, supported by steady retail participation and spillover from derivatives activity.

WORD OF CAUTION

While investor participation remains steady, rising transaction costs following the increase in securities transaction tax (STT) and global uncertainties could weigh on trading activity going forward, the rating agency said.

"Geopolitical tensions and a sustained rise in crude oil prices could increase market volatility and affect investor sentiment, potentially leading to a more cautious approach toward leveraged positions," it said.

ICICI Pru Life FY26 PAT up 34.6% to ₹1,600 cr

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company on Tuesday reported a 34.6 per cent growth in profit after tax to ₹1,600 crore for FY26. The company recorded a net profit of ₹1,189 crore in FY25.

Value of new business (VNB) increased by 10.9 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹2,629 crore with a margin of 24.7 per cent. Its embedded value rose 10.5 per cent y-o-y to ₹52,989 crore in FY26.

The company, in a statement, said that the GST reforms implemented from September 2025 had made insurance policies more affordable, and its retail protection segment registered a 50.9 per cent y-o-y growth in FY26.

360 ONE Asset raises ₹2,000 cr for 'PIPE'line

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Anup Maheshwari, Co-founder and CIO, 360 ONE Asset

360 ONE Asset said it has secured ₹2,000 crore in investor commitments for its Private Investment in Public Equity (PIPE) strategy, signalling a strong appetite for structured capital opportunities in listed Indian companies.

The firm said the PIPE strategy would provide investors with exposure to high-potential opportunities while retaining the liquidity advantages of public markets. It also seeks to address the growing demand for patient, long-term capital to support companies in areas such as growth expansion, governance improvements and balance-sheet optimisation.

Anup Maheshwari, Co-founder and CIO, said the response reflects investor confidence in both the strategy and the firm's ability to execute transactions at scale.

Charanjit Singh, Fund Manager, noted that the portfolio will remain unindexed.

360 ONE Asset manages approximately $11 billion across public and private markets.

Wealth Company MF floats new SIF, 2 NFOs

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Wealth Company Mutual Fund, part of the Pantomath Group, has launched a Specialised Investment Fund under WSIF and announced its maiden NFO of two investment strategies — Equity Long-Short and Equity Ex-Top 100 Long-Short.

The investment strategies combine long-term equity investing with tactical short exposure with an aim to capture market upside while managing downside risks. The minium investment in each strategy is ₹10 lakh per PAN number.

The WSIF Equity Long-Short Fund aims to generate long-term capital appreciation through a diversified portfolio of equities complemented by selective short positions. The investment strategy will maintain equity allocation of 80–100 per cent with flexibility to take up to 25 per cent unhedged short exposure via derivatives.

Madhu Lunawat, Founder, MD & CEO, The Wealth Company Mutual Fund

The WSIF Equity Ex-Top 100 Long-Short Fund focuses on opportunities beyond the top 100 companies by market capitalisation. It will be a minimum of 65 per cent allocation to mid- and small-cap stocks.

Madhu Lunawat, Founder, MD & CEO, The Wealth Company Mutual Fund, said the launch of the SIFs reflects the fund house's commitment to bring institutional-grade investment strategies to investors. It also creates a unique opportunity for distributors to engage with clients on differentiated strategies without legacy biases.

Chinmay Sathe, CIO – SIF, The Wealth Company Mutual Fund, said combining high-conviction long ideas with tactical short exposures will deliver more consistent performance while actively managing downside risks.

In the Ex-Top 100 strategy, there are opportunity sets in the broader market where inefficiencies may be more pronounced, he said.

While traditional mutual funds remain the foundation of long-term wealth creation, SIFs add a powerful satellite layer that equips investors to navigate complex market environments, said the fund house.

QUICKLY.

Citi Group's profit jumps 42% on market volatility

Citi Group's first-quarter profit rose 42 per cent as geopolitical tensions fuelled market volatility and trading revenue, while strong dealmaking buoyed investment banking fees. Profit increased to $5.8 billion from $4.1 billion a year earlier, the lender reported on Tuesday. Shares of the bank rose about 1.3 per cent in premarket trading after the results. REUTERS

Everstone invests $270 m in Apothecon Group

Mumbai: Singapore-based private equity platform Everstone Capital on Tuesday announced a $270 million investment in the Apothecon Group, which is engaged in the pharmaceuticals sector. The investment is in Apothecon and its US-based sister concern Navinta for a "substantial stake", a statement said. PTI

Banks hike spread on repo-linked loans

STRATEGIC MOVE. The mark-up increase, amid sticky deposit rates, is aimed at protecting banks' margins

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

LEADING FROM THE FRONT. The spread on fresh rupee loans was the highest for education loans REUTERS

Banks have increased their spreads for repo-linked external benchmark loans, dampening the extent of transmission of the cumulative 125 bps repo rate cut into such loans.

This comes amid deposit rates turning sticky in the wake of higher interest rates being offered by small scale instruments (SSIs).

So, the increase in spreads (the mark-up charged over and above the policy repo rate) in the case of repo-linked external benchmark loans is aimed at protecting banks' net interest margins.

In the current easing cycle (up to February 2026), as against the 125 bps cut in the repo rate, the WALR (weighted average lending rate) on outstanding loans declined 87 basis points (bps). For fresh rupee loans, the WALR declined 89 bps, according to RBI's latest monetary policy report (MPR).

The WADTDR (weighted average domestic term deposit rate) on outstanding deposits declined by 47 bps. For fresh deposits, the WADTDR declined by 97 bps.

The pass-through from policy rate changes to repo-linked external benchmark loans is one-to-one. But the same in the case of marginal cost of funds based lending rate (MCLR) linked loans and deposit rates happens with a lag.

REPO RATE CUT

Since February 2025, the RBI's rate setting panel has cumulatively cut the repo rate (the interest rate at which the central bank provides liquidity to banks to overcome short-term mismatches) from 6.50 per cent to 5.25 per cent

The spread on fresh rupee loans was the highest for education loans, followed by other personal loans, and MSME loans for domestic banks, per the MPR. The spread for MSME loans increased from 3.20 per cent in January 2025 to 3.29 per cent in February 2026.

For housing and vehicle loans, the spreads increased by 10 basis points each to 2.44 per cent (from 2.34 per cent in January 2025) and 3.17 per cent (3.07 per cent) respectively; for education loans and other personal loans, the spreads increased by 21 bps (4.62 per cent) and 11 bps (to 3.47 per cent) respectively.

Sanjay Agarwal, Senior Director, CareEdge Ratings, said, "Due to sticky deposit rates and competitive pressures in high quality asset segments, banks have chosen to target relatively higher yield customers to protect their net interest margins. Hence, on book basis, the mark-up over external benchmarks has increased."

However on y-o-y basis, overall spreads on fresh loans (lending rates minus deposit rates) have compressed by 13 bps, exhibiting challenges in re-pricing deposits to expected lower levels.

Agarwal said that with significant increase in capital markets yields and overseas borrowings landed costs, the banks' lending rates are expected to inch up in the near term, thereby halting the rate reduction process as on now.

Banking expert V Viswanathan said the effect of reduction in repo rate can be offset by banks through revised spread for new loans to protect their profit margin in the wake of sticky deposit rates.

'Soft drink bottlers to see revenue rebound, driven by summer demand'

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Soft drink makers are expected to see a positive growth trajectory this fiscal, marking a revenue rebound after witnessing a washed out summer season in the last fiscal, according to estimates by CRISIL Ratings.

It noted that soft drink bottlers are poised to see revenue rebound to their long-term average growth of about 15 per cent this fiscal, driven by hotter summer, that account for about 40 per cent, of overall sales and deeper penetration into untapped domestic territories.

Though the impact of sustained elevated crude oil prices on their packaging costs and weather patterns will remain as key monitorables.

The ratings agency noted that there is heightened competition in the space due to entry of new players launching products at popular prices which will lead existing players to ramp up marketing and distribution spends.

Also, a sharp rise in crude prices due to the West Asia conflict has driven up packaging costs, too. These will negatively impact the industry's profitability by up to 250 basis points.

PRICING POWER

"However, the impact will be lower for bottlers with nationwide presence, due to their higher pricing power and better economies of scale. Cash flows of the players will remain healthy, ensuring stable credit profiles," it added.

The estimates are based on analysis of 13 bottlers in the non-alcoholic beverage industry, which includes carbonated soft drinks, juices and packaged water.

"Soft drink bottlers are poised for a strong volume rebound this fiscal driven by hotter summers and rising penetration. Players have not only increased their bottling capacities by 30-35 per cent over the past two fiscals but also expanded their distribution network and cold chain infrastructure. The higher volume, coupled with 2-4 per cent price hike in a competitive environment will help players revert to their long-term revenue growth trajectory," said Shounak Chakravarty, Director, Crisil Ratings,

MARKET SHARE

The ratings agency said the market share of new entrants rose to 6-7 per cent in the last fiscal from about 2 per cent in the FY24.

This is because the newer entrants are targeting impulse purchases through popular price points such as ₹10 and ₹20 bottles.

Rucha Narkar, Associate Director, Crisil Ratings, said, "Intensifying competition will cause a moderation in profitability this fiscal. However, marginal price hikes and increasing focus on zero-sugar variants may limit the overall impact to 200-250 bps, keeping margins healthy at 15-16 per cent."

The ratings agency also indicated that the cash flows will remain healthy for the players, allowing them to continue spending on expanding bottling capacities at outlets, keeping capital expenditure intensity elevated.

'Gold loans emerge as India's 2nd largest retail credit product'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Gold loans have grown rapidly to become India's second-largest retail credit product by balance share after housing loans amid rising borrower adoption, higher ticket sizes and broader lender participation, according to TransUnion CIBIL's Gold Loan Landscape Report.

Even as gold loans share in India's retail credit portfolio has risen 3.8 times from 5.9 per cent in March 2022 to 11.1 per cent by December 2025, the report flagged wallet concentration in gold loans, recent delinquency and high dependence on gold loans within the overall borrower wallet as important forward-risk indicators.

Housing loans with 27.8 per cent share by balance as of December 2025 forms the largest retail credit product.

The Credit Information Bureau (CIB) assessed that the average gold loan balance per account increased from ₹1.1 lakh in March 2022 to ₹1.9 lakh in December 2025, underlining the rising scale of borrowing in the segment.

Gold loan origination volumes have grown 2.3x since Q1 2022, while origination value has increased 5.1x over the same period.

TICKET SIZE

The average ticket size has grown from ₹90,000 in Q1 2022 to ₹1.96 lakh in Q4 2025, indicating that the market is not only widening in reach, but also moving toward higher-value borrowing, according to the report.

The report has also pointed to changing borrower leverage patterns, with the average outstanding amount per borrower going up from ₹1.9 lakh in December 2022 to ₹3.1 lakh in December 2025.

The number of borrowers with gold loan exposure above ₹2.5 lakh increased to 14 per cent of total borrowers at the end of 2025, up from 10 per cent in 2022.

TransUnion CIBIL said borrowers with higher existing balances and greater unsecured exposure have also become more prominent at origination, indicating that gold loans are increasingly sitting alongside other forms of credit in borrower wallets.

The CIB underscored that borrower profiles are changing, with the share of prime and above prime borrowers in gold loan originations rising from 43 per cent in 2022 to around 52 per cent in 2025, while new-to-credit participation declined from 12 per cent to 6 per cent.

The report also highlighted the need for sharper borrower-level risk assessment as the segment grows. Based on the study, for gold loans originated in the six months ended June 2025, overall delinquency was 1.1 per cent.

The study assessed that borrowers whose post-origination gold loan outstanding amount exceeded ₹2.5 lakh, showed a delinquency incidence of 1.5 per cent, about 2.2x that of borrowers with lower exposure, at 0.7 per cent. In addition, wallet concentration in gold loans, recent delinquency and high dependence on gold loans within the overall borrower wallet are important forward-risk indicators.

The report further noted that borrowers with a history of serious delinquency, who subsequently rely on gold loans, face a significantly higher risk of disengagement from the formal credit system. Their credit-access closure rate was around 1.6x higher than that of non-defaulting borrowers, suggesting that for a section of stressed borrowers, gold loans may increasingly be functioning as a product of last resort.

Jain observed that as the gold loan segment expands, lenders' priority must be to balance growth with prudence. "Collateral strength remains important, but it cannot be the sole criterion for evaluating borrowers. "Lenders will need to assess total borrower indebtedness, repayment capacity, recent credit behaviour and cross-lender exposure more holistically," he said.

Vehant Technologies eyes 20% topline from export in 3 years

Rohan Das
Chennai

Kapil Bardeja, Co-founder and CEO, Vehant Technologies

Vehant Technologies, a security solutions company, is looking to scale its international business, targeting 20 per cent of revenues from overseas markets over the next three years.

The company manufactures security and imaging devices such as baggage scanners, vehicle scanners and explosive detectors, among others.

It recently signed a contract to install 22 X-ray baggage scanners in upcoming metro stations in Chennai. It has already installed 11 machines across nine new stations and will install the remaining in the next two-three months. It is also working with eight to 10 city metros in India.

Speaking to *businessline*, Kapil Bardeja, CEO and Co-founder of Vehant Technologies, said the firm closed FY26 with revenues of ₹193 crore, of which 5 per cent came from exports.

"We are currently in about 22 countries, predominantly in Africa, West Asia and parts of Europe and Asia. We believe that we are at a critical scale right now where we can reach out to these markets and expand more aggressively," he said.

Regarding its business in India, Bardeja said the increasing footprint of air passenger traffic is a strong tailwind for the industry. As for the impact of the war in West Asia, Bardeja flagged an increase in input costs. "There has been an overall increase in material costs. Metal prices have jumped about 30 per cent while packing material has increased by 35 per cent," he said.

IPO PLANS

Bardeja further said Vehant operates two manufacturing facilities in Noida and Himachal Pradesh with 70-80 per cent of the components in its products being locally sourced. "There are some import dependencies especially for electronic components," he added.

The firm is also evaluating options for a potential IPO in FY28, and if that happens, it plans to use the proceeds from the listing for improving its R&D capabilities and expanding export business.

Govt should cap product testing charges: GTRI

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government should cap testing charges for routine industrial products as high costs to comply with the quality control orders (QCOs) may impact manufacturing and small importers, think tank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said on Tuesday.

While the QCO policy aims to improve product quality and consumer safety, the pace of expansion is putting pressure on testing infrastructure and has created significant compliance bottlenecks for MSMEs, GTRI said. "India's expanding quality control regime is imposing such high testing and certification costs that many MSME importers may be pushed out of business, leaving the market increasingly dominated by large importers," GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

Kaar Tech strengthens artificial intelligence play, plans data analytics acquisition, IPO

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Maran Nagarajan, CEO, Kaar Tech

Chennai-based Kaar Tech, an AI-led enterprise transformation firm, is positioning itself as an enterprise operating system (EOS) enabler for clients in the AI age, and is looking to close an acquisition in the data analytics space by the end of this fiscal.

The company is targeting firms with capabilities across the full data stack, including analytics, data ingestion, pipelines, and management of data lakes and swamps.

The company, which recently raised $11 million (approximately ₹100 crore) in a Series B primary funding round led by Playbook Partners, is also eyeing an IPO in FY27.

DEEP EXPERTISE

"We have got deep expertise in ERP, cloud, and all such technologies. Data is one space where we think we need to augment our capability," Maran Nagarajan, CEO of Kaar Tech, said. "So, we would be looking at an acquisition in that space. Whether it is an Indian or American or European company, what we are looking for is the customer footprint in the West," he said.

Kaar Tech also plans to file its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) by June 1, 2027, and despite recent corrections in IT stocks, it remains optimistic about long-term market fundamentals.

STRONG VALUE

"The recent downturn is temporary. These companies continue to deliver strong value, and market rationality will eventually return," Nagarajan said.

Founded in 2005 in Chennai, Kaar Tech specialises in EOS modernisation across enterprise applications, data, cloud and AI.

According to the company, traditional enterprise systems such as SAP, Salesforce and Workday will continue to remain foundational.

However, the way enterprises interact with these systems is set to undergo a shift. The next 10 years will be about an AI fabric that sits on top of legacy systems. Enterprises will increasingly interact with their applications through AI-led orchestration layers, rather than directly, Nagarajan said.

The firm, which has around 3,000 employees, believes that revenue growth is not linear any more. "Our revenue per employee is currently at around $66,000, perhaps the highest in the industry, and we aim to increase this by another 10-15 per cent," said Nagarajan.

Kaar Tech has also been steadily pivoting towards Western markets as part of its global expansion strategy.

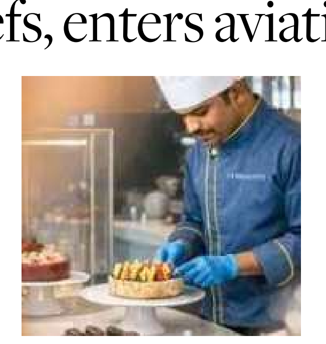
REVENUE SHARE

While nearly 90 per cent of its business came from West Asia a few years ago, the mix is now around 50 per cent West and 50 per cent West Asia, with the share of revenue from the West expected to rise to 60-65 per cent over the next few years.

While geopolitical disruptions in West Asia pose short-term risks, Nagarajan views them as temporary.

Bluspring Enterprises subsidiary to buy LSG Sky Chefs, enters aviation catering

Our Bureau
Bengaluru



Integrated infrastructure services enterprise Bluspring Enterprises Ltd has announced that its whollyowned subsidiary, Bluspring New Horizon Two Private Ltd, has entered into a definitive agreement to acquire 100 per cent shareholding of LSG Sky Chefs (India) Private Ltd (LSG India), marking a strategic entry into the aviation catering sector.

LSG India is owned by AURELIUS, a global private equity firm widely recognised for its operational approach.

The company operates airline catering facilities at Bengaluru and Hyderabad airports. The proposed transaction encompasses the acquisition of the Bengaluru operations, with the Hyderabad operations to be divested before closing. The transaction is expected to close within 60 to 90 days, subject to customary closing conditions.

STRONG PLATFORM

LSG India's Bengaluru operations generate revenue exceeding ₹110 crore, with mid-to-high-teens EBITDA margins.

The acquisition grants Bluspring access to in-flight catering facilities at Bengaluru Airport under a long-term concession agreement valid until 2039.

According to estimates from Bangalore International Airport Ltd, passenger traffic at the airport is projected to grow from approximately 45 million currently to over 70 million by 2030, providing Bluspring with a strong platform to capture high-growth aviation catering opportunities across India.

Kamal Pal Hoda, Executive Director & CEO of Bluspring Enterprises, said: "It [the acquisition] gives us immediate scale in a *niche*, high-entry-barrier segment while creating opportunities to expand into adjacent airport-linked services."

Govt amends pricing norms for low-grade iron ore

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday announced the amendment of rules to revise the pricing norms for low-grade iron ore, a move aimed at curbing wastage and enhancing utilisation of such resources to ensure a steady supply to the steel industry.

The move is expected to bring low-grade resources into viable use, addressing depletion of high-grade deposits and promoting mineral conservation through scientific mining practices.

IRON ORE PRICING

The amendment provides a framework for pricing iron ore with iron (Fe) content below the threshold level of 45 per cent, including banded haematite quartzite (BHQ) and banded haematite jasper (BHJ), the Mines Ministry said.

Under the revised rules, the average selling price (ASP) for iron ore, with 35 per cent to below 45 per cent Fe content, will be fixed at 75 per cent of the ASP of 45 per cent to below 51 per cent grade ore. While for ore with Fe content below 35 per cent, the ASP will be 50 per cent of the same benchmark.

DEDICATED POLICY

Advancements in processing and beneficiation technologies have made subthreshold iron ore resources, such as BHQ and BHJ, viable for upgrading into highgrade ore suitable as feedstock for steel production.

To enable this, a dedicated policy framework was essential for low-grade ore beneficiation, the Ministry said.

India's strong fundamentals to cushion oil shock, growth may slow up to 80 bps: S&P

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India's robust macroeconomic and financial sector fundamentals are likely to cushion the impact of a sustained oil price shock, though economic growth could slow by up to 80 basis points if crude averages $130 per barrel in 2026, according to S&P Global Ratings.

Under its stress scenario, corporate EBITDA could decline 15-25 per cent in FY27, with leverage rising by 0.5x-1x, while banking sector asset quality may weaken, pushing bad loans to around 3.5 per cent.

"India isn't immune to the shocks reverberating from the West Asia war. The pain of higher energy prices and supply disruptions may persist for months, crimping economic activity across households, corporations, and banks," S&P Global Ratings said in a report.

IMPACT BUFFERS

However, strong corporate balance sheets, well-capitalised banks and a resilient external position provide buffers against the impact.

S&P Global Ratings assumes Brent crude at $130 per barrel in 2026 and $100 in 2027 under the stress case, versus a base case of $85 and $70 respectively.

It does not expect any immediate impact on India's sovereign rating, though fiscal consolidation efforts could face temporary setbacks. Higher oil prices could widen the current account deficit, with estimates suggesting a $10 per barrel increase may expand the gap by about 0.4 percentage points of GDP. The rupee could also face depreciation pressures amid risk-off sentiment and a rising import bill.

The agency warned that an energy shock would transmit through higher input costs, squeezed corporate margins, rising consumer prices and increased fiscal strain if the government steps in with subsidies.

Despite these risks, India's economy entered 2026 with strong growth momentum, resilient domestic demand and low inflation, which should help absorb nearterm shocks, it said.

S&P said strong domestic fundamentals, potential government support, and significant improvement in corporate and banking sector health over the past few years would mitigate the severity of any shock.

Inflows into gold ETFs turn positive in past fortnight

LION'S SHARE. Asia ensures inflows remain positive, making up over 86 per cent of net investments so far this year

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Investments in physically-backed gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) turned positive in the past fortnight after turning negative in March. However, for every $3 inflow, there was over a $1 outflow during the period, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) showed.

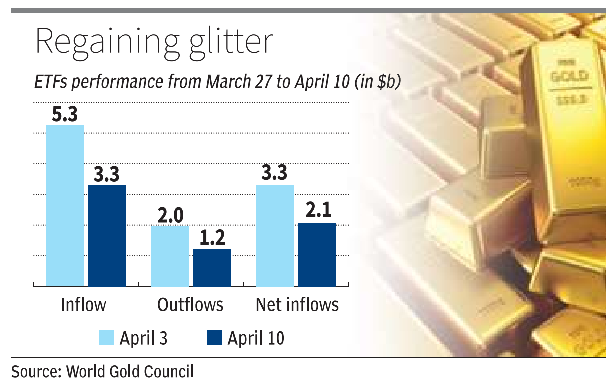
Asia single-handedly ensured that the inflow remained positive till now, with the region making up over 86 per cent of net investments.

The WGC year-to-date (as of April 10) data showed that investments in gold ETFs were more than a year ago, but outflows were also triple what they were a year ago. Net inflows were $10 billion lower than a year ago.

HIGHER EXITS

Investments in gold ETFs in the week ended April 3 were $5.26 billion, and in the week ended April 10, they were $3.3 billion. The outflows were $1.96 billion and $1.23 billion, respectively. Overall, inflows in the funds were $3.3 billion and $2.064 billion.

Year-to-date, investments in gold ETFs totalled $60.17 billion, compared with $43.46 billion a year ago. Investors' exit was $43.05 billion compared with $15.98 billion a year ago. Net investments were $17.12 billion against $27.48 billion last year.



Source: World Gold Council

In the past fortnight, exits from ETFs were more from Canada and Italy. Year-to-date, US investors have chosen to exit ETFs, with net investments turning negative at $264 million. However, US investments in the past fortnight totalled over $1.35 billion. Inflows in Germany were also negative at $204 million.

The UK witnessed huge inflows of $1.33 billion the week ending April 3, while they slowed to $0.38 billion last week. Germany witnessed outflows to the tune of $200 million in the past fortnight, while inflows in Switzerland topped $500 million.

CHINESE LEAD

In Asia, Chinese investments were over $1.3 billion, while Indians invested $168 million in the week ending April 3. Last week's details for India were not available.

Year-to-date, China and India lead the investments in gold ETFs. China's net inflow till now is $9.05 billion, while India's inflow is $3.27 billion. Switzerland ($1.71 billion) and Japan ($1.26 billion) are the other two countries that witnessed significant investments, apart from the UK ($856 million).

Region-wise, fund flows in North America were a negative $68.5 million, while they were up at $1.96 billion in Europe. Investments in Asia increased to $14.84 billion, while in other regions, they were positive at $355 million.

CURRENT PRICES

Gold has gained 10.5 per cent since the beginning of the year, shedding most of its gain after it soared to a record high of $5,608 an ounce on January 29.

Currently, the yellow metal is ruling at $4,774.51 an ounce. Gold futures on the COMEX for June delivery are quoted at $4,797.50 an ounce.

In India, gold June contracts on the MCX ended at ₹1,51,983 per 10 g on Monday. In Mumbai, spot gold prices closed at ₹1,50,011 per 10 g. Markets were closed on Tuesday for Ambedkar Jayanti.

Gold prices had soared in 2024 and 2025 on geopolitical crises, the US Fed proposals to cut interest rates and uncertainty due to the US' trade disputes with other nations.

The precious metal's prices have headed south after the Iran war broke out on fears of inflation, chances of a hike in interest rates, a strong dollar and concerns over the economy.

QUICKLY.

Gold up as oil softens, easing inflation worries

Gold rose on Tuesday as hopes of a resolution in the Iran war pressured the dollar and pushed oil prices lower, easing inflation concerns. Spot gold was up 0.9 per cent at $4,782.19 per ounce as of 1128 GMT. US gold futures for June delivery rose 0.8 per cent to $4,804.70. REUTERS

Copper hits 6-week high on peace talks prospects

London: Copper prices scaled their highest in six weeks on optimism about the possibility of US-Iran peace talks restarting and due to a weaker dollar. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME rose 0.8 per cent to $13,161 a tonne by 0945 GMT. Aluminium dropped 1.1 per cent to $3,567; tin jumped 2.6 per cent to $49,500. REUTERS

Raw sugar off lows as traders weigh supplies

Raw sugar futures edged up as traders weighed tighter supplies ahead versus falling oil prices. Weaker energy prices are bearish for sugar as they can prompt mills to use cane to produce more sugar. Raw sugar edged up 0.1 per cent to 13.69 cents per lb as of 1317 GMT. White sugar fell 0.6 per cent to $408.60 a tonne. REUTERS

Gems & jewellery exports down 35% in March on weak demand

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Gems and jewellery exports plunged 35 per cent to $1.78 billion in March, as demand dipped due to the ongoing Iran war and disruptions in trade flows.

In contrast, imports increased by 17 per cent to $2.31 billion as the industry purchased additional raw materials, including gold and diamonds, in anticipation of a revival in demand, according to data from the Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council.

Cut and polished diamond exports were down 27 per cent at $839 million ($1.16 billion) due to weak global demand and a sharp drop in prices.

The sudden price drop led consumers to reduce fresh purchases in anticipation of further declines. The industry's cut and polished diamond imports increased over four times to $211 million ($51 million).

LGD SHIPMENTS DOWN

Gold jewellery exports were down 48 per cent to $656 million as high gold prices reduced overseas orders, amid inventory adjustments and global economic uncertainty.

Polished lab-grown diamond (LGD) exports were down 28 per cent to $96 million due to weaker global retail demand, increased price competition and inventory correction in key export markets, leading to reduced shipment volumes.

Colin Shah, Managing Director, Kama Jewellery, said it was a mixed bag for gemstone and jewellery exports. Silver and platinum jewellery showed robust growth owing to changing consumer preferences, but traditional metals such as gold jewellery, diamonds and synthetic diamonds came under pressure.

The rise in imports suggests deliberate stockpiling of raw materials in anticipation of a future revival in demand, he said.

SUBDUED FISCAL

Gem and jewellery exports in FY26 were down 3 per cent at $27.72 billion. Conversely, imports increased 17 per cent to $22.83 billion. Cut and polished diamond exports dipped 9 per cent to $12.16 billion.

Rough diamond imports were down 3 per cent at $10.48 billion.

Gold jewellery exports declined marginally to $11.36 billion ($11.37 billion), while silver jewellery exports increased 52 per cent to $1.47 billion.

Basmati rice from Madhya Pradesh is exported to 47 nations, says CM Yadav

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

At a recent gathering of thousands of farmers at Raisen in Madhya Pradesh, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav proudly said the district exported basmati rice to 47 countries. This despite the State not being recognised as a basmati-growing State under the Geographical Indications (GI) definition.

Even as the matter is yet to be settled legally, Yadav's mention of exports happening from Raisen may weaken India's case globally as no major importing country is yet to recognise its basmati GI despite Apeda spending big in the past many years.

The issue of including Madhya Pradesh in the GI area is an emotive issue in the State, first raised by Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan when he was Chief Minister, as the State government had filed a case in GI registry for its inclusion in the geographical area. Under the GI law, even if farmers grow basmati varieties outside the demarcated GI area, those cannot be sold as basmati, making it difficult to get exported.

But Opposition Congress leader Digvijaya Singh last month threatened to go on a hunger strike if the State's farmers do not receive GI benefits for their basmati rice. He wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking GI tag for basmati rice produced in Madhya Pradesh.

PENDING WITH HC

Asked about the demand of Singh, Chouhan said: "You know the matter is in court. We are fighting for the GI.

Mohan Yadav

But this basmati (GI) issue is not only of India, even Pakistan is involved. They (Pakistan) also object. But we have been continuously trying to resolve it."

After a prolonged hearing for years, in February 2016, the Chennai-based GI registry issued the GI certificate to Apeda for basmati rice, under which the recognised area included some districts of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Haryana, western Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Delhi. The order was upheld by the GI appellate tribunal, dismissing the appeal of the Madhya Pradesh government for the State's inclusion. When the matter reached the Madras High Court in 2020, it asked the Madhya Pradesh government why it had not pursued the statutory remedy of seeking cancellation or modification of the GI certificate issued to Apeda before the Registrar of Trade Marks, and dismissed the petition.

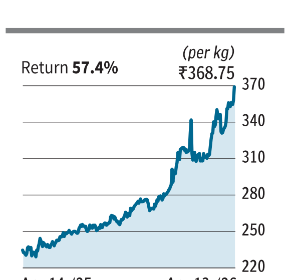
However, the State moved the Supreme Court, which in September 2021, remanded the case for fresh consideration within three months. The matter has since remained pending.

Buy aluminium futures; raise stop-loss to ₹355

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Aluminium futures were up 3.1 per cent on Monday. This led to the breakout of a range and opened the door for further gains.

The April contract, which was oscillating between ₹350 and ₹358 since the beginning of the month, surpassed the barrier at ₹358 on Monday and ended the session at ₹368.75.



COMMODITY CALL.

While there is a chance for a corrective dip from the current level, possibly to ₹365, the April futures are likely to extend the rally to ₹380.

A breakout of ₹380 could take the contract to ₹400. On the other hand, if the contract slips below ₹365, it ccould drop further to retest ₹350. A breakdown below ₹358 could turn the outlook weak, possibly leading to a quick fall to ₹345, its 21-day moving average.

Overall, the outlook remains positive, and the price action conforms to the same.

TRADE STRATEGY

We recommended buying aluminium futures at ₹340 a couple of weeks ago.

Retain this trade but raise the stop-loss from ₹340 to ₹355.

Book profits at ₹380.

'Fertilizer cost surge may hit global coffee output'

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The International Coffee Organisation (ICO) said on Tuesday that rising fertilizer prices linked to geopolitical tensions in West Asia pose a risk of pushing up costs for coffee growers worldwide and could impact production.

In its latest market report for March, the ICO said the long-term effect of sustained high fertilizer prices could significantly impact production. "While production for the current 2025-26 crop is not likely to suffer significantly as fertilizers have already been applied in most cases, it creates some risks for the 2026-27 crop if the disruption is prolonged. Between one-fourth and one-third of the global fertilizer trade, and up to one-third of nitrogen fertilizers (urea), transits through the Strait of Hormuz. The Gulf region also is a major producer of fertilizers," it said.

The latest ICO report also showed that global coffee prices rebounded in March 2026 after three months of decline, driven largely by tensions in West Asia that disrupted shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz.

The benchmark ICO Composite Indicator Price rose 2.3 per cent month-on-month to 273.7 cents per pound, reflecting heightened freight costs and supply chain uncertainty. Around 25 per cent of the world's seaborne oil trade transits through the Strait of Hormuz, along with almost 20 per cent of global liquefied natural gas exports.

MIXED PRICE TRENDS

Colombian Milds' and Other Milds' prices expanded 2 per cent and 4 per cent in March compared to February, averaging 337.45 and 334.34 cents/lb, respectively. Brazilian Naturals' prices grew 3.9 per cent to 320.51 cents/lb in March.

In the same month, robustas declined by 1.6 per cent to 176.77 cents/lb. Prices at the London Intercontinental Commodity Exchange (ICE) market decreased by 2.5 per cent to 161.91 cents/lb, while the New York ICE market increased by 0.5 per cent to 290.18 cents/lb in March.

INDIA GAINS

For India, the developments had a mixed impact. The country benefited from tighter global supplies and disruptions in competing origins such as Vietnam.

Coffee exports rose an estimated 38.5 per cent in February to about 0.79 million bags, up from 0.57 million a year earlier, partially offsetting a 4.7 per cent decline in shipments from the Asia and Oceania region.

The surge came as Vietnam, the world's largest robusta exporter, saw shipments drop sharply due to the timing of the Tet holiday.

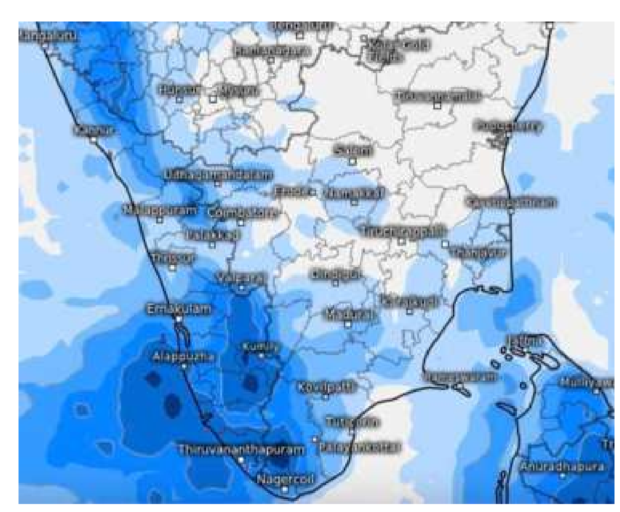
This created an opening for Indian exporters, especially in robusta and soluble coffee, to gain market share. Other producers, including Brazil and Indonesia, also benefited from Vietnam's temporary slowdown.

Globally, however, exports weakened. Robusta green bean shipments fell 3.7 per cent year-on-year to 4.05 million bags in February, largely due to Vietnam's decline.

Total coffee exports dropped 5.7 per cent to 11.46 million bags, reflecting reduced supplies from major producers such as Brazil and Colombia. South America's exports plunged 21.8 per cent, with Colombia hit by lower production.

Against this backdrop, India's coffee exports hit a record $2.136 billion in FY26, supported by higher prices and a modest rise in volumes to over 4.07 lakh tonnes.

Temperatures may trend up over N-W, Central parts of India until the weekend



PICK-UP IN RAIN. The European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts' multi-model outlook indicates that thundershowers (in blue) are likely to become better organised over Kerala early next week WWW.METEOLOGIX.COM/IN

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

A day after the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued its first long-range outlook pointing to a below-normal monsoon this year, it warned of a fresh spell of rising temperatures across North-West and Central India over the next 4-5 days as a 'heat engine' in the form of an anticyclone claws its way back.

In contrast, widespread pre-monsoon showers are expected over the North-East States and the hills of North-West India, with isolated activity likely over Gujarat and parts of the Western Peninsula in the ensuing three days.

The evolving weather pattern is being closely tracked as meteorologists look for early signals ahead of the informal yet closely watched 40-day window leading up to the monsoon's onset in June.

PRE-MONSOON PEAK

This period, beginning around April 22, coincides with the so-called pre-monsoon rainfall peak over the Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea.

It is typically marked by a band of rain-bearing clouds stretching eastward from Kerala into the Bay, a feature that may develop anytime between early April and mid-May.

The timing of the 'peak' offers a broad indication of the likely date of monsoon onset over Kerala.

LEAD UP TO MONSOON

Numerical weather models of the IMD, corroborated by guidance from the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts, broadly support this outlook.

If the trends hold, the monsoon may arrive around its usual time or marginally earlier, though confirmation will depend on evolution, intensity and spatial spread of thunderstorms.

Satellite imagery on Tuesday indicated scattered cloud clusters to the south of Sri Lanka drifting into the Lakshadweep Sea, bounded by Sri Lanka, India and the Maldives.

At the same time, a more extensive, lightning-laden mass of thunderstorms was seen building over the south-east Bay of Bengal as if poised to link up with this cloud band, subject to favourable shifts in the prevailing wind pattern.

NAAS flags need for smart alternative fertilizers to achieve self-sufficiency

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The National Academy of Agricultural Sciences (NAAS), the apex body of agriculture scientists headed by the Director-General of the Indian Council of Agriculture Research (ICAR), on Tuesday laid emphasis on strengthening research for the development of smart alternative fertilizers, among other measures, to become self-sufficient in crop nutrients by 2047.

Addressing the media after a day-long brainstorming session to develop a roadmap for achieving *aatmanirbharta* (self-reliance) in fertilizers, ICAR's DG ML Jat said the roadmap should emphasise strengthening fertilizer research for development of smart alternate fertilizers, utilisation of unexploited indigenous minerals (glauconite, phosphate rocks, mica, polyhalite) and industrial byproducts.

He stressed on the increased use of biologicals, exploiting the potential of soil microbiome, improved composting techniques, crop breeding for enhanced NUE, good agricultural practices (GAP) involving precision nutrient management integrating fertilizers and organics, soil health restoration, crop diversification and residue recycling.

CURRENT CHALLENGE

The closed-door meeting held in New Delhi was attended by representatives from concerned government departments, academia, the fertilizer industry and farmers, where it was unanimously agreed on the necessity of achieving *aatmanirbharta* in this critical sector.

Highlighting that the country consumes nearly 33 million tonnes of fertilizers (in terms of nutrients) annually, he said a significant share of this comes through import. Stating that reducing import dependency had become imperative, he said it needs a comprehensive approach, separate short-term, medium-term and long-term strategies.

Modern technologies, such as precision nutrient management, AI and sensor-based systems to optimise fertilizer use, should be adopted. Crop diversification towards pulses and oilseeds, recycling organic waste and increasing the use of biological sources will contribute to reducing the dependence on chemical fertilizers, Jat added.

Soybean imports up at 3.09 lt during Oct-March of this season

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Soybean imports increased to over 3.09 lakh tonnes (lt) during the October-March period of the 2025-26 oil year over 0.02 lt in the same period a year ago.

DN Pathak, Executive Director, The Soyabean Processors Association of India (SOPA), attributed the uptrend to improving commercial viability amidst the tightness in the domestic demand supply situation. SOPA has projected imports of 6 lt for the oil year 2025-26, ending September.

India allows the import of only non-genetically modified (non-GMO) soybean and the key origins for such imports are producers in West Africa.

Imports from these African producers are allowed at zero duty under the least developed countries scheme.

PRODUCTION DOWN

SOPA has projected a decline in soybean output at 110.26 lt for the oil year 2025-26 over previous year's 128.82 lt.

Of the estimated production of 110 lt, about 63 lt have arrived in the market during October-March, down from the corresponding last year's 72 lt.

As a result of the lower arrivals, the crushing of soybean has also been lower at 57 lt (60.5 lt). Stocks with the trade and the government agencies are estimated at 51.1 lt. The Central agencies are holding about 7 lt of soybean procured under the price support scheme.

Due to the lower crushing, the production of meal also declined to 44.98 lt (44.74 lt). The offtake of meal from the feed segment is flat at 32.50 lt, while the food segment witnessed a marginal decline at 4.20 lt (4.35 lt).

Exports of soymeal were down 30 per cent at 7.72 lt during the October-March period on higher domestic prices.

QUICKLY.

GAIL to invest ₹3,800 crore in 700 MW solar projects

New Delhi: GAIL (India) Ltd said it will invest ₹3,800 crore to set up 700 MW of solar power capacity across Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. It will develop a 600-MW solar project with a 550-MWh battery energy storage system at the TUSCO Solar Park in Jhansi to meet the captive power needs of its petrochemical plant in Pata, UP. It will also set up a 100-MW project with a 22-MWh storage system in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, Maharashtra, to cater to its PDH-PP plant in Raigad. PTI

9 dead, 15 injured in boiler blast at Vedanta Power

Sakti (Chhattisgarh): Nine people were killed and 15 injured in a boiler blast at the Vedanta Power Plant in Sakti district on Tuesday, the police said. The injured have been taken to a hospital in Raigarh. "We are in the process of ascertaining details, and a thorough investigation has been initiated," a spokesperson from the plant said. ANI

Prime Minister opens ₹12,000-crore Delhi–Dehradun economic corridor

KEY INFRASTRUCTURE. Expressway to cut travel time, reduce logistics costs and support tourism and jobs

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

NEW BEGINNING. Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the inauguration event in Dehradun on Tuesday. Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami (right) and Governor Lt Gen (retd) Gurmeet Singh are also present ANI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday inaugurated the Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor, describing it as a key infrastructure milestone for Uttarakhand and the north Indian region.

Speaking at the inauguration, he said the corridor will improve connectivity, reduce travel time and lower fuel consumption and freight costs, while facilitating employment generation.

FOR CONNECTIVITY

The project forms part of the Centre's broader push to expand infrastructure across road, rail and air networks.

The Prime Minister stated that India's annual infrastructure spending had increased from less than ₹2 lakh crore before 2014 to over ₹12 lakh crore, with projects worth more than ₹2.25 lakh crore currently underway in Uttarakhand.

LOGISTICS PUSH

Besides, the corridor is expected to support regional economic activity by improving access to key cities including Ghaziabad, Baghpat, Baraut, Shamli and Saharanpur.

Further, the Prime Minister said the project will open opportunities in trade, logistics, warehousing and industry, while also benefiting farmers and livestock owners through faster market access. In terms of operational aspects, the project has seen an investment of about ₹12,000 crore and has generated employment for engineers, labourers and transport workers.

Additionally, tourism connectivity to Dehradun, Haridwar, Rishikesh, Mussoorie and the Char Dham circuit is set to improve.

Modi said that rising tourist inflows, including winter pilgrimages, are contributing to local economic activity across sectors, such as hospitality and transport.

In addition, the project incorporates environmental safeguards, including a nearly 12-km elevated wildlife corridor to minimise disruption to animal movement.

According to the Prime Minister, the government expects the corridor to provide sustained momentum to Uttarakhand's development while balancing infrastructure expansion with environmental conservation.

KEY FEATURES

The key features of the corridor include a six-lane access-controlled highway aimed at reducing travel time between Delhi and Dehradun from about six hours to nearly 2.5 hours.

The project includes 10 interchanges, three railway overbridges, four major bridges and multiple wayside amenities to enable smoother and safer movement of passengers and goods. It also connects with major expressways such as the Delhi–Mumbai and the Delhi–Meerut ones, while also linking upcoming corridors.

Samrat Chaudhary to take over as first BJP CM of Bihar

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

Bihar Ex-CM Nitish Kumar and Samrat Chaudhary (left)

A major political transition is underway in Bihar as Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Chaudhary, the OBC face of the BJP, is set to replace Nitish Kumar, who quit as Chief Minister on Tuesday, marking an end to an unparalleled tenure spanning over two decades in Patna.

Chaudhary, the newly-elected leader of the BJP legislative party, will take over as Bihar Chief Minister on Wednesday.

He was unanimously elected the leader of the NDA legislative party, paving the way for him to become the first BJP CM of Bihar, said Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai.

CASTE ARITHMETIC

Choudhary, 57, belongs to the Koeri-Kushwaha caste which accounts for 4.2 per cent of Bihar's population. Koeris are said to be influential in the State's caste arithmetic, besides Yadavs, in the OBC blocs. Together with Kurmis, to which Nitish Kumar belongs, Koeri are described as the "Luv-Kush" alliance by political observers.

Kumar has now shifted to Delhi and is a member of the Rajya Sabha.

Choudhary expressed his gratitude to the central leadership of the BJP for giving him an opportunity to serve the people and vowed to fulfil their dreams and win their trust.

"I express my heartfelt gratitude to the central leadership of the Bharatiya Janata Party for reposing their trust in me by assigning the responsibility of leader of the BJP Bihar Legislative Party. This is not merely a position for me, but a sacred opportunity to serve the people of Bihar, to fulfill their trust and dreams. I pledge to live up to the expectations of one and all with complete dedication, commitment and integrity," he posted on X.

"Under the able leadership of the country's esteemed Prime Minister Shri @narendramodi ji and the guidance of the honorable National President Shri @NitinNabin ji, I will remain continuously committed to taking Bihar to new heights of development, good governance, and prosperity. Your affection, blessings, and cooperation are my greatest strength. Jai Bihar, Jai Bharat!" he added.

"..The vision of Viksit Bharat of PM Modi and that of prosperous Bihar by Nitish Kumar — together we will make Bihar prosperous and make the country developed," he added.

Born in a politically influential family in Munger district on November 16, 1968, Choudhary began his career with the Rashtriya Janata Dal and even served as a Minister during former Chief Minister Rabri Devi's tenure.

He, however, joined the BJP in 2018 — a move that was politically rewarding since his graph went up within the party.

A year later, he became deputy to State BJP president Nityanand Rai, and was subsequently appointed Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Council. Choudhary became BJP's Bihar president in 2023.

Cabinet Secy highlights need for sovereign AI model, civil-military cooperation

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan ANI

Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan has emphasised to the senior leadership of the Army about the critical need to develop sovereign artificial intelligence models and have resilient supply chains to safeguard national interests amid evolving geopolitical challenges.

His address at the ongoing Army Commanders' Conference flagged the importance of key strategic imperatives for national preparedness in an increasingly complex global environment, said Army officials.

Somanathan also stressed on the necessity of stronger civil-military cooperation and observed that a whole-of-nation approach was essential for achieving optimal outcomes in both conflict and peace time.

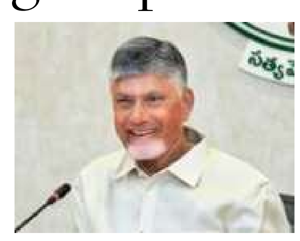
NATIONAL MINDSET

Speaking on *aatmanirbharta*, the Cabinet Secretary described it not merely as a policy objective, but as a national mindset in which every sector, every institution and every citizen contributes towards building a self-reliant and resilient India. The interaction formed part of the ongoing Army Commanders' Conference deliberations focused on strengthening national security, preparedness and institutional synergy.

The first Army Commanders' Conference this year is taking place in the national capital from April 13 to April 16 and will focus on strategic, operational and policy matters to create a future-ready land force.

'AP is building deep-tech ecosystem'

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu

Andhra Pradesh is building a deep-tech ecosystem, Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said.

He was speaking after inaugurating India's first open-access Quantum Reference Facilities in Amaravati on Tuesday, which is also World Quantum Day.

The Bharat Quantum Reference Facility (Amaravati 1 S) has been set up at SRM University, Amaravati, while QBiT Tech's facility (Amaravati 1Q) is at Medha Towers, Gannavaram. "The launch of the facilities in Amaravati was a successful case study for technological convergence," Naidu said. A strong national technological consortium, including different institutes with different capabilities, provided an indigenous supply chain to set up the facilities, he added.

INDUSTRY LINK

The Chief Minister inaugurated the facility on the SRM University campus, and the Gannavaram facility was opened virtually.

"The two systems will strengthen the academic ecosystem for quantum skills and the industry interface," he added.

L Venkat Subramanian, Founder of QBiT Force, which built the two quantum computing testing facilities, said that with the support of the State government and technology institutions, which supplied all Made-in-India components, the facilities could be deployed in record time of four months.

Secretary, DST, Abhay Karandikar, said Amaravati Quantum Valley was reflecting the vision of the State to develop technologies for the future. It had all the potential to become a hub for quantum tech and skill training. The Centre has supported 300 professionals and created 17 start-ups for creating a quantum ecosystem , he said.

63 moons' cybersecurity arm pilots GPS-spoofing solution at Indian airports

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Srinivas L, Joint MD & CEO of 63SATS Cybertech

63SATS Cybertech, the cybersecurity business unit of 63 moons Technologies, is collaborating with two airports to develop a solution to combat GPS-spoofing, a major threat to the aviation industry, a top official in the cybersecurity firm said.

"We have a solution from Israel that we are actively piloting with two airports in India," Srinivas L, Joint MD & CEO of 63SATS Cybertech, told *businessline*, adding that Noida International Airport is among its customers.

SIGNAL SPOOFING

Srinivas explained that GPS spoofing works by transmitting a fake ground-based GPS signal that is stronger than those sent by satellites.

Aircraft normally rely on weak signals from satellites thousands of kilometres away, but when a stronger, false signal is broadcast, the their systems can pick that up instead.

As a result, the aircraft may interpret its position incorrectly, believing that it is in a different location than its actual one. This could also mislead air traffic control, which may see the aircraft positioned somewhere it is not.

Last December, GPS spoofing was detected at major airports, including Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru.

The proliferation of connected devices, particularly in homes, and increasing threats because of that had prompted 63SATS to develop solutions under its CYBX brand, its superapp.

"It is about convenience versus security. That's the toughest piece to solve," said Srinivas. "So, in the next two to three years, you will see a lot of IPs coming out of our stable," he added.

The company has rolled out an upgraded version of CYBX, positioning it as an all-in-one solution. The new version integrates multiple security layers, ranging from encrypted calling and Wi-Fi protection to defence against over 100 attack vectors.

Srinivas said the app was seeing good traction, clocking 700,000 downloads and blocking nearly 1.4 million cyberattacks within a month of its launch in August 2025.

Beyond retail users, 63SATS operates across enterprise and government segments through its Cyber Security Force and Cyberdome platforms.

The company is also working with several State government bodies for securing the energy infrastructure network and providing AI cybersecurity, said Srinivas, adding that talks were on with the governments of Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Tamil Nadu.

"Now, we are focusing on the energy sector and the telecom sector, specialising in operational technology security," he added.

In its enterprise business 63SATS has tied up with top global brands such as Palo Alto, Check Point and Fortinet for providing cybersecurity solutions to sectors such as BFSI, manufacturing, automotive and critical infrastructure.

Stalin warns of widespread agitation if South's representation is hit by delimitation

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin

As the Centre convenes a special session of Parliament on April 16 to introduce a Constitution Amendment Bill, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin on Tuesday issued a warning to the government over the proposed delimitation exercise, alleging that the Centre was attempting to push through a Constitutional amendment without consultation and in the midst of ongoing elections.

He cautioned that any step which results in undermining the political representation of the southern States will lead to widespread protests in Tamil Nadu. He put out a video message amid the election campaign, saying that "grave danger has now reached the doorstep of Tamil Nadu", and issued a "final warning" from Tamil Nadu directly to the Prime Minister. Talking about the special session of Parliament on April 16, he said it was a "hurried attempt" to push through delimitation and is "a blatant assault on democracy" and on the rights of the States by the BJP government.

Stalin said Parliament was being "forcibly convened" in the midst of elections in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal. "In the forthcoming Parliamentary session, our Members of Parliament will participate. But if anything is done that harms Tamil Nadu or that disproportionately enhances the political power of northern States, we in Tamil Nadu will not remain silent," he said in his message, being seen as a warning to the BJP and the PM.

NO DISTRACTION

"Tamil Nadu will rise. Tamil Nadu will register its protest with full force. Every family will take to the streets," Stalin said, referring to a massive agitation.

"Do not assume that since this is an election period and attention is elsewhere, you can quietly carry out delimitation in Delhi," he said.

Regarding the DMK's issues with the special session on April 16, Stalin said the Centre intends to "bulldoze through a Constitutional amendment on delimitation", something the Dravidian party had always been warning about and for which it had brought together a Joint Action Committee.

"When the Union government urged us to control population growth, to have smaller families and to follow family planning measures, we complied. Is this now the punishment for having done with discipline what was asked of us?" the CM asked.

He noted that there had been no response from the PM to their request to provide a clear assurance in Parliament that the southern States would not be affected. "Meeting time has also been denied for our MPs," he added.

"Thus, ignoring everything we have said, without consulting not just the DMK but any political party or any State, they are attempting to proceed unilaterally," he said.

He ended his statement, directly addressing the PM: "You will witness a Tamil Nadu that you have not seen before. India will once again witness the spirit of the DMK of the 1950s and 1960s... This is a warning issued from Tamil Nadu," he said.

Wonderla launches Terrea resort in Bengaluru, expands hospitality push

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Amusement park operator Wonderla has deepened its hospitality ambitions with the launch of Terrea by Wonderla, an earth-inspired urban resort adjacent to its Bengaluru park, as it looks to tap into rising demand for premium, experience-led stays.

The property was revamped over eight months with an investment of around ₹18 crore. "We have had this resort in Bengaluru for over a decade, but we wanted to give it a new identity and a distinct brand of its own," said Arun K Chittilappilly, Executive Chairman & Managing Director, Wonderla Holidays Ltd.

"We saw a demand for premium, differentiated offerings, and wanted to extend that to our resort business," he told *businessline*.

The 84-room resort has been designed around nature-led themes. "We wanted every room to feel different, unlike typical hotels where the experience is largely uniform," Chittilappilly noted.

The launch builds on Wonderla's earlier hospitality venture, The Isle by Wonderla. "We want to position this as a lifestyle brand with a clear value proposition rather than just an extension of the amusement park," Chittilappilly said.

Wonderla is also evaluating expanding the format to other cities such as Kochi, Hyderabad and Chennai.

Footfalls at Asia's largest tulip garden decline amid West Asia conflict, security concerns

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

TOURISM DIP. Just about 3.4 lakh tourists visited the garden between March 16 and April 1 against 8.55 lakh in the same period last year, a 60 per cent drop PTI

Asia's largest tulip garden in Srinagar will close to the public from the evening of April 16 as the season comes to an end with visitor numbers this year significantly lower than last season.

The decision to shut the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden was taken following recommendations by the Tulip Committee and a team of experts, according to a notice issued by the Directorate of Floriculture, Gardens and Parks, Kashmir.

Stakeholders attributed the decline in footfalls to the ongoing conflict in West Asia and the lingering impact of last year's militant attack in Pahalgam, which they said had dampened tourist inflows.

Just about 3.4 lakh tourists visited the garden between March 16 and April 13, an official from the department said, against 8.55 lakh during the same period last year.

"Despite the lower turnout, the garden remained a key attraction during the spring season," the official said.

MORALE HIT

Spread over an area of 30 hectares at the foothills of the Zabarwan range overlooking Dal Lake, the garden features around 70 varieties of tulips. It was established in 2008 to extend Kashmir's tourism season beyond the summer months and has since become a major draw for visitors during spring.

Qazi Tauseef, spokesperson for the Kashmir Economic Alliance, a coalition representing more than a dozen trade bodies, said geopolitical tensions were weighing on the tourism sector.

"The Iran conflict has led to a reduced inflow of tourists. Unusually high airfares have discouraged budget and middle-class travellers, making Kashmir less accessible at a time when affordability plays a crucial role in travel planning," he said.

Telangana govt ready for talks with transport staff: Minister

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Telangana government is ready for a dialogue with employees of the Telangana State Road Transport Corporation to look into their demand, State Transport Minister Ponnam Prabhakar said on Tuesday, urging the staff to call off their plan to strike.

Referring to a strike call from April 22 pushing for the merger of the corporation with the State government, recognition of RTC labour unions and an increase in wages, among others, the Minister said a committee had been formed by the previous government to look into their demands.

The government had undertaken many reforms, including the introduction of the Mahalakshmi Scheme to provide free travel to women on State-run buses, which increased the revenue of the corporation, he added. Provident fund (PF) dues were reduced by the present Congress government from ₹1,205 crore to ₹600 crore. Apart from introducing 2,978 new buses, the government also gave compassionate appointments to 1,134 people, he added.

QUICKLY.

Amazon to buy Globalstar for $11.6 billion

Amazon.com agreed to acquire satellite operator Globalstar in a roughly $11.6 billion deal that would boost the tech giant's efforts to build its own satellite operation. Amazon is offering Globalstar shareholders either $90 in cash per share, or 0.32 shares of Amazon stock with value capped at $90 a share, according to a statement on Tuesday. The $90-per-share offer represents a 23.5 per cent premium over Globalstar's Monday closing price. The deal is expected to close in 2027. *Bloomberg* had reported earlier that Amazon was in talks to buy Globalstar. BLOOMBERG

GE Aerospace, HAL closer to sealing jet engine deal

New Delhi: GE Aerospace on Tuesday announced that it has made significant progress with Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) in putting together a collaboration to co-produce F414-INS6 jet engines to power LCA Tejas Mk-2 and other future combat jets. The F414-INS6 is expected to offer significant power boost of 98 kN thrust on the LCA Mk1 variant. The deal is likely to be signed later this year after the commercial negotiation gets over. OUR BUREAU

Sony bags TV and digital rights for football league

Mumbai: Sony Pictures Networks India (SPNI) on Tuesday said it has acquired the television and digital rights for the Indian Football League (IFL), formerly known as the I-League, for the 2025-26 season. With this, SPNI's football portfolio now includes the Indian Super League (ISL), the Indian Football League, the UEFA Champions League, the UEFA Europa League, and more. Rajesh Kaul, Business Head, Sports and International, Sony Pictures Networks India, said, "With this acquisition, we are further strengthening our football offering and building a more complete ecosystem for fans in India." OUR BUREAU

Quantum mission to achieve 2,000 km network by 2027

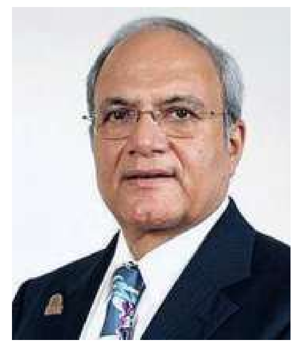
AHEAD OF SCHEDULE. Initiative will strengthen India's position in cybersecurity

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The National Quantum Mission (NQM) is set to achieve a 2,000 km quantum communication network by the second half of 2027, four years ahead of its eight-year plan.

The NQM had set a target of establishing a 2,000 km quantum communication network over eight years since its launch in 2024-25. However, with 1,000 km already completed in the first two years, the entire network will be completed by 2027.

> We will have a powerful quantum computer available in the next five years to be utilised for different applications
>
> **AJAI CHOWDHRY**
> Chairman of Mission Governing Board of NQM



QUANTUM SECURITY

"We are world-class [in quantum security] because the highest amount of quantum secure network is now developed and installed in India," said Ajai Chowdhry, Chairman of the Mission Governing Board of NQM, while speaking to *businessline*.

Quantum networks are required to ensure highly secure pathways of data transfer, especially when using quantum computers. Earlier, the NQM had anticipated a decade before the threat of quantum hacking, in which a powerful quantum computer attempts to break through cybersecurity measures. However, with recent developments over the past month, the NQM noted reports claiming D-day could be as early as 2029.

While stressing that telecom, banking and finance, security, intelligence, defence and electrical grids particularly heed such threats, Chowdhry said, "The good news is that the hardware and software required for doing this is available indigenously, and we are specifically stating that we should use indigenous products."

This, in turn, means the country does not need to import quantum components, which are expected to face heavy export sanctions globally going forward.

Regarding NQM's other goals, such as quantum computing, Chowdhry said the 1,000-qubit quantum computer should be ready within the next four to five years.

"We will have a good, powerful quantum computer available in the next four-five years to be utilised for different applications. One of the biggest benefits of this will be AI," said Chowdhry.

The Chairman expected AI and quantum to work "beautifully together", especially as future data centres are expected to be a mix of hybrid quantum and classical systems.

GLOBAL STANDING

When asked about India's status in the global ecosystem, Chowdhry said the country is leading in quantum communication and sensing but lags in quantum computing.

"In quantum computing, we are a little behind (compared to other countries) but that doesn't matter. Supposing sanctions come out, then even a 1,000 qubit would be good enough," he said, pointing out that India is also working on additional technologies like superconducting, photonics, semiconductor technology, and ion and neutral atoms.

Further, Indian start-ups are exporting their products to the US, with some software companies interested in integrating them into their systems. "There is a global market for this," said Chowdhry.

Airport tariff cut to have minimal impact on revenue: India Ratings

Our Bureau
Mumbai

HELPING HAND. The reduction in airport tariff is one of the steps taken by the government to cushion the impact of the West Asia crisis on the aviation sector

The mandated reduction in landing and parking charges at airports will have 1-2 per cent impact on their annual revenue and is largely credit neutral for operators, India Ratings and Research said in its analysis on Tuesday.

Strong liquidity and non-aeronautical revenue will help airports balance the impact of the mandated 25 per cent reduction, it added.

PARKING CHARGES

On April 7, the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA) announced a 25 per cent reduction in landing and parking charges for domestic flights at major airports in the country for three months.

The reduction in airport tariff is one of the steps taken by the government to cushion the impact of the West Asia crisis on the aviation sector. Overall, the landing and parking charges (for domestic and international flights) account for an average of around 20 per cent of total airport revenues, and the 25 per cent reduction in charges for a three-month period is estimated to result in a revenue moderation of 1-2 per cent. "While the temporary measure impacts revenues by just 1-2 per cent, strong liquidity and non-aeronautical income help balance the effects," said Suryanarayanan S, Senior Analyst, India Ratings & Research.

"However, any extension beyond the initial three months could weigh on aeronautical revenues. Additionally, the broader economic environment should be considered, as changes in passenger demand and airline operations could further impact the airports," he said.

Along with reduced airport tariff, the government extended price relief for fuel too. Price hikes in aviation turbine fuel (ATF) for scheduled domestic flights has been limited to 25 per cent.

The government is also considering a new version of the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme for distressed sectors. Airlines may get up to ₹5,000 crore credit under the proposed scheme.

TRAVEL OPTION

"The primary focus of the government in the aviation sector has been to make flying a more affordable and convenient travel option for passengers. Even in the prevailing challenging situation, when global air operations are impacted, we have ensured that cancellations and rising fuel costs do not severely affect the operations of our domestic carriers. While ATF costs globally have risen by more than 100 per cent, we have passed on only a moderate increase capped at 25 per cent," Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu said last week.

Novo Nordisk to use OpenAI for quicker drug development

Reuters
London

Danish drugmaker Novo Nordisk, which has fallen behind Eli Lilly in the immensely lucrative weight-loss drug market, said on Tuesday that it is partnering with OpenAI to deploy artificial intelligence (AI) across its businesses, from drug discovery to manufacturing and commercial operations.

The maker of Wegovy and Ozempic said the partnership would use OpenAI's technology to analyse complex datasets, identify promising drug candidates and improve efficiency in manufacturing, supply chains, distribution and corporate operations.

Drugmakers are increasingly using AI to streamline the more tedious parts of drug development, from finding clinical trial participants and selecting sites to preparing regulatory filings, though industry executives say the technology has not yet fully delivered on the harder task of discovering major new molecules.

Novo is seeking new ways to regain ground in an intensifying obesity-drug battle with Lilly, which this month won US approval for its weight-loss pill Foundayo after Novo launched oral Wegovy in January.

AI LITERACY

Novo did not disclose financial terms of the agreement. It said pilot programmes would begin across research and development, manufacturing and commercial operations, with full integration planned by the end of 2026.

Novo said OpenAI will also help train its global workforce, increasing AI literacy and boosting productivity across departments.

Novo said the partnership included strict data protection, governance and human oversight.

Bank accounts of accused under the lens in TCS harassment case

Press Trust of India
Nashik

Bank accounts of the accused arrested in connection with the sexual harassment and religious conversion case involving some women employees of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) BPO are being investigated to check whether they received funds for carrying out illegal activities, sources said.

The case is being investigated by a special investigation team (SIT).

The bank accounts of the accused are being investigated to determine the source of funds, sources in the police said on Tuesday, without elaborating.

A local court on Monday extended the police custody of the female operations manager of the BPO until April 15 in connection with the case.

Seven employees of TCS, including six men and a woman, have been arrested so far. Another female employee is absconding, according to investigators.

SIT INVESTIGATION

Earlier this week, the police formed an SIT to probe the complaints lodged by eight female employees, who claimed that senior colleagues had mentally and sexually harassed them, and the Human Resources Department had ignored their complaints.

The arrested employees, who have since been suspended, have been identified as Danish Sheikh, Tausif Attar, Raza Memon, Shahrukh Qureshi, Shafi Sheikh, Asif Aftab Ansari and Ashwini Chainani, police said.

TCS on Sunday said that it has adopted a zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and coercion of any form for a long time, confirming the suspension of the employees allegedly involved in sexual harassment at its Nashik office.

On Monday, Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran termed the sexual harassment as "gravely concerning and anguishing", and announced that a thorough investigation is underway under TCS's Chief Operating Officer Arathi Subramanian to establish the facts and identify individuals responsible for the situation.

OpenAI's $852 b valuation faces investor scrutiny

Reuters

OpenAI's $852 billion valuation is under scrutiny from some of its own backers as the company shifts its focus to the enterprise market to fend off competition from Anthropic, the *Financial Times* reported on Tuesday.

Last month, OpenAI raised $122 billion in what would likely rank as the largest fundraising round in Silicon Valley history. However, the company has redrawn its product roadmap twice in the past six months in response to competitive threats, first from Google and then from Anthropic.

According to the report, some OpenAI investors said that the changes could leave it vulnerable to Anthropic and a resurgent Google.